

ORAL INTERPRETATION OF LITERATURE



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Oral Interpretation of Literature

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This text was compiled on 01/16/2026

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Welcome

Peer reviewers:

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Welcome

You have started an exciting journey into a course I consider “the best kept secret on campus.” Welcome to the wonderful world of oral interpretation of literature!

What will you be doing? You will be learning how to perform literature in this course through analysis, finding relevant and significant messages, and using your voice and body to bring the literature to life for your audience. This course is unlike any other you have taken before.

You may be coming into this course with previous experience in public speaking or maybe high school debate. Or, perhaps you have been in theatre or plays but have never tried this type of performance. Or, maybe you have no experience at all in speeches or theatre but were intrigued by the “literature” aspect of the title. Or, perhaps you selected this course because a friend told you it was fun or because it was the only one that fit your schedule. Regardless of motive, I believe you will find value in the skills you learn from this class.

One of my former students called this his “dessert class.” It was the part of his education “meal” that semester to which he looked the most forward. It gave him a chance to exercise a different part of his brain than was required of him in math, history, or even his English courses. I think you will find that while this course certainly involves “work,” the sort of work you will do is of a much more creative sort. If you put forth the effort, you will enjoy the process and the fruits of your labor if you allow yourself to play.

Note: You may occasionally see reference in this text to you, the performer, as an “interper.” This is a term of endearment from me to you, the student of oral interpretation of literature, as you navigate this fun and challenging world.

The Nature of Play

When the poet William Stafford was asked when he first realized that he wanted to be a poet, he responded: My question is “When did other people give up the idea of being a poet?” You know, when we are kids we make up things, we write, and for me the puzzle is not that some people are still writing, the real question is why did the other people stop?

Other artists have asked similar questions and made similar assertions. “Every child is an artist,” said the dramatist and poet Percy Mackaye, “with imagination and the artistic instinct. Life stamps these out—and in only a few cases, those we call geniuses, do they rise, and become sculptors, artists, poets—great creators.”

What both Stafford and Mackaye observe is the fact that we all naturally possess the ability to be expressive, to give free rein to our imaginations, to invent, to bring into the world something new. As Stafford notes, as children we naturally enjoy “making up things.” We delight in imagining, in creating, in *playing* with colors, shapes, with words—so why then do many of us stop playing, or stop being, as Mackaye says, “an artist?”

It is quite useful for us to answer this question as we become oral interpreters of literature. If we can understand the barriers to “performance” in front of others, then we can move past stagnant periods of creativity by finding ways to avoid the barriers or bring them down. One of the obstacles to being creative, whether through painting or performing literature, is our tendency to be critical and judgmental of ourselves and our art—especially while in the process of creating it. If we are in the middle of writing a poem and begin to doubt ourselves or tell ourselves that what we are writing is silly or just not good, then we are standing in the way of our creative act of play and our growth as a writer. If we are practicing our prose performance and begin to think we can’t possibly measure up to other performers we have seen on stage or online, we become our own obstacle.

Think about what it means to play. The Merriam-Webster dictionary provides the following definition of “[play](#).”

a: recreational activity; *especially*: the spontaneous activity of children

c: the act or an instance of playing on words or speech sounds

When we play, we are spontaneous. When we play, we do not aim to harm ourselves—physically or with harsh criticism that stops us from playing. And when we play, we pay attention to words and sounds. Imagine children playing. See two girls in a pink bedroom sitting at a tea table surrounded by stuffed animals. One of them wears a tiara. The other has wrapped a scarf around her head pretending to be a unicorn. The princess sips her tea and speaks of how warm the sun is on her shoulders, how the warmth turns everything blue into diamonds. The unicorn responds, “This scarf isn’t working. I don’t look enough like a unicorn.”

In this example, the girl with the scarf has broken the spell of imagination necessary for play. It is no different than when we criticize our own creative works while in a state of creating—of playing—only in this case we are saying, “This literature isn’t working” or “My body language and voice aren’t good enough for this.” To perform literature, we must be willing to indulge the creative state, to forgive ourselves as we create, to enjoy and appreciate what we have in front of us and how it develops under our creative flow—especially in the early stages of creating an interpretive performance.

In oral interpretation, there is always the opportunity to revise. An interpretive performance has its own life, and for some interpers, it may never be finished. And this is okay. The creative process can be expressed in an endless variety of ways. For as many people as there are living on this planet, there are as many, if not more, ways of expressing creative impulses. It is my hope that in your journey through this course, this text will act as a guide to nurturing your own natural creativity.

Attributions

Adapted from <https://milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/naming-the-unnameable/front-matter/introduction-our-natural-right-to-play/>.

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1.1: Introduction

The Nature of Oral Interpretation of Literature

In this course, you will learn a less conventional sort of “public speaking.” Communicating messages through the oral interpretation of literature (also known as “oral interp”) is an effective means to share important information. In fact, as Todd Lewis notes in *Communicating Literature*, alternative sorts of messages can lend themselves to better understanding, empathy, and attitude/behavioral change than other modes/contexts of communication (Lewis, 2019, p. 33). In oral interp, instead of stating messages directly and defending ideas through traditional organizational patterns and delivery styles (i.e. a speech), you use arrangement and performance of literature to communicate important ideas to your audience.

Through various forms of “play,” this course will teach you how to analyze literature and bring it to life for others through your voice and body language. To do this, you will be analyzing various forms of literature, pulling out meaningful themes and making them relevant for your audience. You will arrange literature in ways that highlight the messages you wish to convey, and you will use vocal elements and body language to express the feelings and emotions that accompany, compliment, and amplify the messages in literature that you choose to perform. Sounds like fun, doesn’t it?

Whether this course is part of your major course of study or whether it is one you chose to compliment your general education, please remember that any communicative act we choose to present or perform in front of others has an impact. Performer, audience, and literature work together in a beautiful transactional synergy (more on this later). You will discover that oral interpretation of literature can be a highly effective and rewarding way to find your “voice.”

Although the term oral interpretation may be new to you, the experience of interpreting literature is part of everyday life. Lawyers read evidence to a jury. Pastors read prayers. Parents and teachers read to their children. This course will impress upon you the value of bringing more expression and meaning to reading the written word.

Additionally, you will find you often engage in vocal and bodily “performance” daily in every role we play – employee, student, family member, friend, parent. If you’ve ever had to smile at work to customers even though you have a migraine, or if you’ve had to ensure you appear confident in front of a pushy salesperson while negotiating a price on that a car, you know about the value of performance in our everyday lives. Using our voice and body more expressively can help ensure our messages are received more accurately.

When you complete this course, you will be able to:

- Analyze literary merit and meanings of various forms of literature.
- Create and present literature performances appropriately adapted for an audience.
- Demonstrate emotion and characterization through controlled vocal and nonverbal behaviors.
- Evaluate the effectiveness of oral interpretation performances through constructive critique.

Attributions

Adapted from <https://moodle.linnbenton.edu/course/view.php?id=4645#section-1>.

Essential Tools

If you commit to this course and the work and play within it, you will experience many benefits. To excel, you will need the following tools every day that you come to class:

Something *On* Which to Write

While this course may not be as lecture heavy as others in which you might enroll, you will take notes. Additionally, when you are engaged in various individual or group activities involving creative thought, movement, and play, you will often need to jot ideas down and use them during the activity. Therefore, using a notebook or paper (rather than a laptop) is best for this course.

Something *With* Which to Write

In addition to taking notes on lectures and using paper during class activities, you will often be writing on literature samples and scripts passed out in class. You should always have a pen or pencil to do this sort of work.

A Binder

While this item is optional, you will find that using a small and/or thin, three-ring binder will be a helpful way to organize and keep your scripts for performance. Most oral interpers use these binders when they perform to prevent having to hold multiple, cumbersome books or floppy pieces of stapled paper.

Forgiveness

In her essay “The Getaway Car: A Practical Memoir About Writing and Life,” from her collection of essays, *This Is the Story of a Happy Marriage*, Ann Patchett lists forgiveness as being one of the essential skills necessary to write successfully. We can apply the same philosophy to literature performance:

Forgiveness. The ability to forgive oneself. Stop here for a few breaths and think about this because it is the key to making art, and very possibly the key to finding any semblance of happiness in life. Every time I have set out to translate the book (or story, or hopelessly long essay) that exists in such brilliant detail on the big screen of my limbic system onto a piece of paper (which, let’s face it, was once a towering tree crowned with leaves and a home to birds), I grieve for my own lack of talent and intelligence. Every. Single. Time. Were I smarter, more gifted, I could pin down a closer facsimile of the wonders I see. I believe, more than anything, that this grief of constantly having to face down our own inadequacies is what keeps people from being writers. Forgiveness, therefore, is key. I can’t write the book I want to write, but I can and will write the book I am capable of writing. Again and again throughout the course of my life I will forgive myself.

Patchett’s advice is simple yet insightful. Even more, she is totally right. Artists experience the feeling of failure frequently. The key is learning how to embrace our mistakes as we create art and grow from those errors.

While I have a master’s degree in Communication Studies and have been doing oral interp since the age of six, the creative process has not gotten any easier for me over the years. Of course, mechanics have gotten easier (confidence in front of others, elimination of stutters and stumbles, etc.). I have found ways to organize myself and develop habits—some good, some bad—that can advance (or hinder) my creative processes. The more one creates and performs and watches others create and perform, the more aware one becomes of different ways to create and perform. We must all learn from the moments where we weren’t quite able to perform to the best of our abilities.

But there are some struggles that never go away. These struggles can be different for each person. For me, I tend to procrastinate after I have collected various pieces of literature that I would like to compile into an interp program. I become paralyzed at the thought of having to organize it all, finding beginning and ending spots, and it’s hard for me to focus and begin the work. But, if I commit myself to the mode of creating, lighten my inherent self-criticism, and permit myself to find “flow,” it becomes pleasurable.

Not only is forgiveness a necessary part of the creative process in the sense that we cannot translate exactly to an audience what we see and hear in a piece of literature, but also in the sense that good oral interp performances often deal with sensitive, difficult-to-approach subjects. Being creative in the face of these subjects often takes much mental and emotional effort, and I therefore find forgiving myself for past actions, thoughts, and desires—for feeling the way I do—necessary to create a performance that deals with these sorts of topics. You may decide to perform works that expose some of your personal memories and feelings, and some of these may be a bit uncomfortable to consider. You may decide to perform literature that reveals insight into how you truly feel about a parent or sibling or friend. Or, a certain poem or story you wish to perform may force you realize how you may have hurt someone in your past or neglected someone you love. We all make mistakes, and mistakes sometimes make good subject matter for performance. So, start forgiving yourself and move onward.

Receptivity

The mindset of forgiveness that Patchett describes is similar to what William Stafford writes in his little essay “A Way of Writing” when he recommends that a writer must “be willing to fail” in order to be successful. The same is true of learning to “perform,” using your voice and body on stage in more expressive ways than one has done in the past. One cannot expect any performance to be perfect. The creative process relies upon trust—you must trust that what you are doing will go somewhere.

This course requires that you be receptive to feedback. You will be learning how to evaluate oral interp performances in this course, and we will employ these evaluative techniques sometimes even on days where we are “playing” and engaging in creative

activities. Be ready to not only *give* positive and helpful, constructive feedback to your peers, but be ready to also *receive* it. If you are fully receptive to critique, you will improve your skills.

You may find that when you give yourself a willingness to receive criticism, a wonderful freedom emerges. If a creative idea for a character occurs while you are playing in class, or if you see a unique theme in a piece of literature, it becomes all right to run with it. You learn to follow your impulses and see where they lead. You give yourself permission to be “careless of failure” (Stafford) as you play and learn.

Additionally, you should stay receptive to new ideas. Abandoning preconceived notions of popular literary works can help you see new possibilities for using a piece of literature in performance. Staying open to various ways a character can be performed from a literary work that may have been turned into a movie or show you have seen can give your performance uniqueness, as opposed to simply being viewed as an imitation of someone else’s work. As Morpheus told Neo in the movie, *The Matrix*, you should allow this course to “free your mind.”

Silliness

I have always told my students that in order to break through confidence barriers you may have about this course, you will need to “leave your egos at the door.” You will need a free mind to examine literary works in new ways and/or portray a character that has voice and movement different from your own. If you are continually worried about looking goofy when you raise your vocal inflection or change your body posture to imitate a five-year-old child, it is very difficult to fully commit to being creative.



Figure 1.1.1: Students being silly after an interpretation showcase event, Clovis Community College, 2016

Why prescribe silliness? For possibility. For new ways of thinking and writing. For fun. If you’re worried that you may not have it in you, don’t. The fact that you are even taking an “arts” course like this on creative oral expression of literature means that this quality, this playfulness, is already inherent in you.

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Adapted from <https://milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/naming-the-unnameable/front-matter/introduction-our-natural-right-to-play/>.

Ethics

As mentioned in a previous section, this course will give you a new and exciting way to find your “voice” as a public communicator. With this gift of voice comes great power, and as Uncle Ben said to Peter Parker in the Spider-Man movies, “With great power comes great responsibility.”

All communication has ethical implications. Communication ethics deal with the process of negotiating and reflecting on our actions and communication regarding what we believe to be right and wrong. Aristotle said, “In the arena of human life, the honors and rewards fall to those who show their good qualities in action” (Pearson et al., 2006). Aristotle focuses on actions, which is an

important part of communication ethics. While ethics has been studied as a part of philosophy since the time of Aristotle, only more recently has it become applied. In communication ethics, we are more concerned with the decisions people make about what is right and wrong than the systems, philosophies, or religions that inform those decisions. Much of ethics is gray area. Although we talk about making decisions in terms of what is right and what is wrong, the choice is rarely that simple. Aristotle goes on to say that we should act “to the right extent, at the right time, with the right motive, and in the right way.” This quote connects to communication competence, which focuses on communicating effectively and appropriately.

Communication has broad ethical implications. But, when dealing with communication ethics, it’s difficult to state that something is 100 percent ethical or unethical. We make choices daily that are more ethical or less ethical, and we may confidently decide only later to learn that it wasn’t be most ethical option. In this course, you will learn to analyze your audience. You will strive to learn their general attitudes, values, beliefs, and preferences, and you will use this information as you choose and analyze the literature you perform as well as the messages you choose to emphasize within it. You will even use this information as you organize your performance programs, compose your performance introductions, and create mannerisms and characters for the various personae you perform.

Sometimes, the literature you choose, the messages you send, or the themes you highlight in a text may touch upon a topic that is uncomfortable for your audience. Perhaps the subject matter is sensitive or the topic is controversial and opposite of most of your audience members’ views. These sorts of topics deserve careful consideration as you craft the performance that includes them, taking care to present the ideas with respect and always keeping your audience in mind. We should not necessarily shy away from difficult topics in oral interp but rather learn to present and perform them in a way that inspires our audience to listen willingly and engage in the material as it is performed. As communicators, we want people to receive the messages we send, so we must craft our messages in ways that invoke in them a desire to listen.

Since many of the choices we make when it comes to ethics are situational, contextual, and personal, various professional fields have developed codes of ethics to help guide members through areas that might otherwise be gray or uncertain. You may find it useful to consider guidance from the National Communication Association (NCA), the professional organization that represents communication scholars and practitioners in the United States, when you craft your messages and performances in this course. The NCA’s “Credo for Ethical Communication” reminds us that communication ethics are relevant across contexts and apply to every channel of communication, including media (National Communication Association, 2012). The credo goes on to say that human worth and dignity are fostered through ethical communication practices such as truthfulness, fairness, integrity, and respect for self and others. The emphasis in the credo and in the study of communication ethics is on practices and actions rather than thoughts and philosophies. Many people claim high ethical standards but do not live up to them in practice. While the credo advocates for, endorses, and promotes certain ideals, it is up to each one of us to put them into practice. The following are some of the principles stated in the credo:

- We endorse freedom of expression, diversity of perspective, and tolerance of dissent to achieve the informed and responsible decision making fundamental to a civil society.
- We condemn communication that degrades individuals and humanity through the expression of intolerance and hatred.
- We are committed to the courageous expression of personal convictions in pursuit of fairness and justice.
- We accept responsibility for the short- and long-term consequences of our own communication and expect the same of others.

Attributions

Adapted from <https://open.lib.umn.edu/communication/chapter/1-3-communication-principles/>.

Synergy: Analysis/Message/Performance

The beauty of oral interpretation literature performance exists in its synergy of three elements: analysis, message, and performance. In a sense, this course involves skills that are explored in three other courses with which you may be familiar: English Literature, Public Speaking, and Drama/Theatre. You do not need to have experience in these courses to be successful in this one. This course simply gives you the opportunity to see how disciplines can complement one another.

Analysis

In an English Literature class, you read essays and novels with an eye for finding and analyzing relevant themes and ideas in the texts. Students examine plot, characterization, writing style, and more to discern what message the author may have intended in the

work and perhaps how the literature's existence has impacted society.

The first step in creating an oral interpretation performance is to analyze the literature you choose for performance. Like an English Literature student, you will examine all aspects of your chosen text, diving into denotative and connotative meaning, studying the relationships between characters, finding common themes and ideas, etc. This examination will lead to the next stage of the interpretation performance process.

Message

In a Public Speaking course, you construct an oral presentation using research and organization to support and informative or persuasive thesis statement. You learn that the first step in speech construction is not selecting a topic but rather analyzing your audience so as to choose a topic and approach that will be valuable and significant to your audience. This process of considering one's audience and choosing a message or theme also occurs as one develops an oral interpretation performance.

Through your literary analysis, you will be searching for universal themes, morals, lessons, and thesis statements you can use to connect to your audience. Rather than simply performing literature for performance's sake, your presentations will include original introductions (you will write them) that highlight these themes for your audience. These messages will provide focus for your audience on the meaning of the literature, giving them something that can apply to their lives in a significant manner and inspire them to pay attention to the performance.

Performance

In a theatre or drama course, students learn to use their voice and body to bring a script to life for an audience. They study their assigned role or character, make choices in how that character would look, talk, walk, and respond to stimuli and others around him/her, and embody that character fully in body language and vocal characteristics as they work with others in a scene or play on stage.

To bring our chosen literature to life for our audience, we will also use the various elements of voice and body language to transmit not only the content of our literature but the feelings and emotions inherent with it to our audience. With our voices, we can use changes in rate, tone, articulation, resonance, volume, and more. With our bodies, we can use variations in posture, facial expressions, eye gazes (focal points), hand gestures, etc. It is through the use of variations in these elements that we can bring our literature to life in front of our audience.



Figure 1.1.2: Student, Kaylee Fowler, performs children's literature at a showcase event, Clovis Community College, 2019

Differences Between Theatre and Oral Interpretation

At this point, it will be helpful to understand that while acting in a play or movie and oral interpretation have similarities, there are some distinctions.

In theatre acting (stage plays, musicals, television, movies), emphasis is placed largely on spectacle (costumes, props, scenery, lighting). Actors typically memorize scripts and play only one character (exceptions to this latter characteristic being in large musicals). Actors maintain what is called an on-stage focus; as they interact, they look directly at one another in conversations (on-stage focus). Actors in these contexts typically perform only one work of literature at a time.

In contrast, in oral Interpretation, there is no spectacle. Interpers do not wear costumes, no props (or very few) are used, and there are no special scenery or lighting effects. Performers will often hold their literature/script(s), and rather than memorizing, aim for a sense of familiarity that allows them to lift their eyes from the page to gaze at the audience or focal points. Performers will often play multiple characters in oral interp and maintain a mostly off-stage or audience gaze with their focal points (see chapter 4 for more on eye contact and focal points). Many times, oral interpretation performers will present programs that contain more than one work of literature.

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1.2: Communication Apprehension

If you feel fear, anxiety, or discomfort when confronted with the task of being in front of an audience, you are not alone. National polls consistently show that public speaking is among Americans' top fears (Bodie, 2010). Yet, this is a fear that many people must face regularly; and you will need to face it in this course. Effectively managing nervousness has many positive effects on your performance such as fewer feelings of anxiety on the inside and a more relaxed and confident delivery on the outside. Although speech/performance anxiety (also known as stage fright) is natural and normal, it can interfere with verbal and nonverbal delivery, which makes a presentation less effective. In this chapter, we will explore causes of presentation anxiety, ways to address it, and best practices of vocal and physical delivery.

Sources of Speaking Anxiety

Aside from the self-reported data in national surveys that rank the fear of public speaking high for Americans, decades of research conducted by communication scholars shows that communication apprehension is common among college students (Priem & Solomon, 2009). Communication apprehension (CA) is fear or anxiety experienced by a person due to real or perceived communication with another person or persons. CA is a more general term that includes multiple forms of communication, not just public speaking. CA can be further broken down into two categories. "Trait CA" refers to a general tendency to experience anxiety related to communication, in essence incorporating it into a person's personality. "State CA" refers to anxiety related to communication that occurs in a particular situation and time (Bodie, 2010). Of college students, 15 to 20 percent experience high trait CA, meaning they are generally anxious about communication. Seventy percent of college students experience some trait CA, which means that addressing communication anxiety in a class like the one you're taking now stands to benefit most students (Priem & Solomon, 2009).

Whether CA is a personal trait or not, we all occasionally experience state CA. Think about the jitters you get before a first date, a job interview, or the first day of school. The novelty or uncertainty of some situations is a common trigger for communication anxiety, and public speaking is a situation that is uncertain for many. This course, in particular is quite novel for most students and, therefore, can sometimes result in uncertainty and anxiety.

Public speaking or performance anxiety is a type of CA that produces physiological, cognitive, and behavioral reactions in people when faced with a real or imagined presentation in front of others (Bodie, 2010). Physiological responses to this anxiety include increased heart rate, flushing of the skin or face, and sweaty palms, among other things. These reactions are the result of natural chemical processes in the human body. The fight or flight instinct helped early humans survive threatening situations. When faced with a ferocious saber-toothed tiger, for example, the body released adrenaline, cortisol, and other hormones that increased heart rate and blood pressure to get more energy to the brain, organs, and muscles in order to respond to the threat. We can be thankful for this evolutionary advantage, but our physiology hasn't caught up with our new ways of life. Our bodies don't distinguish between the causes of stressful situations, so facing down an audience releases the same hormones as facing down a wild beast.

Cognitive reactions to presentation anxiety often include intrusive thoughts that can increase anxiety: "People are judging me," "I'm not going to do well," and "I'm going to forget what to say." These thoughts are reactions to the physiological changes in the body but also bring in the social/public aspect of public presentation in which speakers fear being negatively judged or evaluated because of their anxiety. The physiological and cognitive responses to anxiety lead to behavioral changes. All these thoughts may lead someone to stop a presentation or performance and return to their seat or leave the classroom. Anticipating these reactions can also lead to avoidance behavior where people intentionally avoid situations where they will have to present in front of an audience.

Addressing Presentation Anxiety

While we can't stop the innate physiological reactions related to anxiety from occurring, we do have some control over how we cognitively process them and the behaviors that result. Research on public speaking anxiety has focused on three key ways to address it: systematic desensitization, cognitive restructuring, and skills training (Bodie, 2010).

Systematic Desensitization

Although systematic desensitization may sound like something that would be done to you while strapped down in the basement of a scary hospital, it actually refers to the fact that we become less anxious about something when we are exposed to it more often

(Bodie, 2010). As was mentioned earlier, the novelty and uncertainty of public speaking is a source for many people's anxiety. So, becoming more familiar with public presentation by doing it more often can logically reduce the novelty and uncertainty of it.

Systematic desensitization can result from imagined or real exposure to anxiety-inducing scenarios. In some cases, an instructor leads a person through a series of relaxation techniques. Once relaxed, the person is asked to imagine a series of scenarios including speech preparation and speech delivery. This is something you could also try to do on your own before performing. Imagine yourself going through the process of preparing and practicing an oral interp performance, then delivering it, then returning to your seat. Aside from this imagined exposure to performance situations, taking a course like this one is a great way to directly engage in systematic desensitization. Almost all of my students report that they have less performance anxiety at the end of a semester than when they started, which is at least partially due to the fact they were forced to engage with it more than they would have done if they weren't taking the class.

You will have ample opportunities to engage in activities and games and practice performances in this course before you present one for a grade, so take advantage of as many of these as you can.

Cognitive Restructuring

Cognitive restructuring entails changing the way we think about something. A first step in restructuring how we deal with performance anxiety is to cognitively process through our fears to realize that many of the thoughts associated with stage fright are irrational (Allen, Hunter & Donohue, 2009). For example, people report a fear of public speaking over a fear of snakes, heights, financial ruin, or even death. It's irrational to think that the consequences of giving a presentation in public are more calamitous than getting bitten by a rattlesnake, falling off a building, or dying. People also fear being embarrassed because they mess up or are evaluated negatively. Well, one cannot literally die from embarrassment, and in reality, audiences are very forgiving and overlook or don't even notice many errors that we, as performers, may dwell on. Once we realize that the potential negative consequences of giving a presentation are not as dire as we think they are, we can move on to other cognitive restructuring strategies.

Positive visualization is another way to engage in cognitive restructuring. Speaking anxiety often leads people to view their own presentations negatively, even if their performances were good. They're also likely to set up negative self-fulfilling prophecies that will hinder their performance in future presentations. To effectively use positive visualization, it's best to engage first in some relaxation exercises such as deep breathing or stretching, which we will discuss more later, and then play through vivid images in your mind of giving a successful performance. This should be done a few times before giving the actual performance. Students sometimes question the power of positive visualization, thinking that it sounds corny. Ask an Olympic diver what his or her coach says to do before jumping off the diving board and the answer will probably be "Coach says to imagine completing a perfect 10 dive." Likewise, a Marine sharpshooter would likely say his commanding officer says to imagine hitting the target before pulling the trigger. In both instances, positive visualization is being used in high-stakes situations. If it's good enough for Olympic athletes and snipers, it's good enough for oral interpers.

Skills Training

Skills training is a strategy for managing presentation anxiety that focuses on learning skills that will improve specific presentation behaviors. These skills may relate to any part of the oral interp process: literature selection, theme/message development, organization of multiple texts, delivery, and self-evaluation. Like systematic desensitization, skills training makes the presentation process more familiar for a performer, which lessens uncertainty. In addition, targeting specific areas and then improving on them builds more confidence which can, in turn, lead to more improvement.

Feedback is important to initiate and maintain this positive cycle of improvement. You can use the constructive criticism that you get from your instructor and peers in this class to target specific areas of improvement. Self-evaluation is also an important part of skills training. Make sure to evaluate yourself within the context of your assignment and the expectations for the performance. Don't get sidetracked by a small delivery error if the expectations for content far outweigh the expectations for delivery. Combine your self-evaluation with the feedback from your instructor and/or peers to set specific and measurable goals and then assess whether you meet them in subsequent performances. Once you achieve a goal, mark it off your list, and use it as a confidence booster. If you don't achieve a goal, figure out why and adjust your strategies to try to meet it in the future.

We will slowly build skills for creating oral interpretation performances in this course. You will get chances in class to play with each step in the process in our classroom's low-stakes environment before you combine all skills for a comprehensive, graded

performance.

WANT to Perform

Oral interpretation of literature is an artful and creative way for you to share literature and messages that are important to you with others. When you've gone through the work of finding literary texts, analyzed them, and arranged them into a program, it would be a shame to let that creation sit in your backpack. Tap into the motivation that drew you to create that work and realize the power of sharing it with others. Your creation can impact, affect, and influence others. It's amazing how we can break through nerves when we view our goals as important.

Try not to worry too much about being new to this art form. Audiences in this beginning course are generally very forgiving, supportive, and most feel the same anxiety you are feeling. If we can simply find the *desire* to perform, that can propel us forward. Performance skills can be learned, practiced, and perfected, and the number one thing you need to do to be a successful oral interp performer is to want to be there. If you feel good about the literary texts you choose for a performance, and if you find that desire to share them with your audience, be patient with yourself. The performance skills will come, and you will find ways to successfully manage the anxiety you initially feel.

Be Prepared

Procrastination increases anxiety, particularly in contexts with which we are unfamiliar. You can mitigate this uneasiness by preparing your interpretation performances well in advance. This gives you time to ask your instructor if you have questions during the construction process. It gives you time to practice and gain muscle memory for movements and particular vocalizations. Do not wait until the night before a performance is due to begin putting it together or practicing it, or you surely find your performance anxiety levels increase. You may find it helpful to your nerves to have a literature program organized and ready for rehearsal at least a week in advance.

You will find that some performance day routines will also help ease the jitters. Get a good night's sleep the night before and go for a little run that morning or do some stretching to get your heart pumping. Be sure to eat an hour or two before you perform to give you energy. Wear something that gives you confidence. Do something that relaxes you before you head to your performance space, like sip a cup of orange tea or take a long shower. The routine of doing something creates a pattern in our minds and bodies that makes it easier to relax and prepare for the task at hand.

Arrive early on your performance day, find your seat, and get comfortable. Chat with others around you and try to click in with the creative energy of the room. This work may seem unimportant to the overall product that is your performance, but it can go a long way to helping you perform your best on that day.

Physical Relaxation Exercises

Suggestions for managing performance anxiety typically address its cognitive and behavioral components while the physical components are left unattended. As we learned earlier, we can't block these natural and instinctual responses. We can, however, engage in physical relaxation exercises to counteract the general physical signs of anxiety caused by cortisol and adrenaline release, which include increased heart rate, trembling, flushing, high blood pressure, and speech disfluency.

We might compare confronting the physical aspects of public speaking anxiety to chemical warfare. Some breathing and stretching exercises release endorphins, which are your body's natural antidote to stress hormones. You can release endorphins, slow your heart rate, calm your nerves, and help your focus before performing through just a few deep breaths. Breathing provides a general sense of relaxation and can be done discreetly, even while waiting to speak.

To get the benefits of deep breathing, you must breathe into your diaphragm. The diaphragm is the muscle below your lungs that helps you breathe and stand up straight, which makes it a good muscle for a speaker to exercise. To start, breathe in slowly through your nose, filling the bottom parts of your lungs up with air. While doing this, your belly should pooch out. Hold the breath for three to five full seconds and then let it out slowly through your mouth. After doing this only a few times, many students report that they can feel a flooding of endorphins, which creates a brief "light-headed" feeling. Once you have practiced and are comfortable with the technique, you can do this before you perform, and no one sitting around you will even notice. You might also want to try this technique during other stressful situations. Deep breathing before dealing with an angry customer or loved one, or before taking a test, can help you relax and focus.

Stretching is another way to release endorphins quickly and effectively. Since we use our bodies more expressively in oral interpretation performances than we might in a traditional public speech, stretching can be a very useful pre-performance tool.



Figure 1.2.1: [Public Domain Pictures](#): Discretely stretching your wrists and calf muscles is a good way to relieve anxiety and get your energy flowing while waiting to speak.

Ancient exercise traditions like yoga, tai chi, and Pilates teach the idea that stretching is a key component of having a healthy mind and spirit. In general, exercise is a good stress reliever, but many of us don't have the time or willpower to do it. We can, however, take time to do some stretching. Obviously, it would be distracting for the surrounding audience if a performer broke into some planking or a tree pose just before his or her performance. However, even simple and discreet stretches can help get the body's energy moving around, which can make a performer feel more balanced and relaxed. Our blood and our energy/stress tend to pool in our legs, especially when we're sitting.

The following stretch can help manage the physical manifestations of anxiety while you are waiting to perform. Start with both feet flat on the floor. Raise your back heels off the floor and flex and release your calf muscles. You can flex and release your calves once before putting your heels back down and repeating, or you can flex a few times on each repetition. Doing this three to five times should sufficiently get your blood and energy flowing. Stretching your wrists can also help move energy around in your upper body, since ample time spent typing and using other electronic controllers put a lot of stress on this intersection of muscles, tendons, and bones. Point one hand up at the wrist joint, like you're waving at someone. Then use your other hand to pull, gently, the hand that's pointing up back toward your elbow. Stop pulling once you feel some tension. Hold the hand there for a few seconds and release. Then point the hand down at the wrist joint like you're pointing at something on the floor and use the other hand to push the hand back toward your elbow. Again, stop pushing when you feel the tension, hold the stretch for a few seconds, and release. You can often do this stretch discretely as well while waiting to speak.

These physical exercises can work wonders to calm your nerves. Even, closing your eyes for a few seconds can help center you, too. All these techniques can help make your performance experience a good one, and the more you do them, the easier it becomes to control your anxiousness.

Vocal Warm-Up Exercises

Vocal warm-up exercises are a good way to warm up your face and mouth muscles, which can help prevent some of the fluency issues that occur when speaking. Newscasters, singers, and professional speakers use vocal warm-ups. They can also help lighten the mood if done in groups.

The list that follows includes specific words and exercises designed to warm up different muscles and different aspects of your voice. After going through just a few, you should be able to feel the blood circulating in your face muscles more. It's a surprisingly good workout!

- Purse your lips together and make a motorboat sound. Hold it for ten seconds and repeat.
"BBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBBB."
- Clench your teeth and say, "N, N, N, N," to stretch your cheek muscles.
- Say "Mum" five times and open your mouth and eyes wide each time you say it.
- Say "Puh" five times, making sure to use your diaphragm to enunciate the h.

- Say “Red Rover” ten times, overenunciating each r.
- Say “Wilbur” ten times, overenunciating the w and r.
- Say “Bumblebee” ten times, enunciating each b.
- Say “Red letter, yellow letter” five times, making sure to distinctly pronounce each word.
- Say “Selfish shellfish” five times, making sure to distinctly pronounce each word.
- Say “Unique New York” five times, enunciating the q and k.

You will likely see nerves begin to dissipate once you have taken these pains to warm up your voice and body, just as an athlete would warm up before a game.

Attributions

Top Ten Ways to Reduce Speaking Anxiety

As you can see in this section, there are many factors that contribute to presentation anxiety, and there are many ways to address it. The following is a list of the top ten ways to reduce presentation anxiety which helps review what we’ve learned:

1. Remember, you are not alone. Presentation anxiety is common, so don’t ignore it—confront it.
2. Remember, you can’t literally “die of embarrassment.” Audiences are forgiving and understanding.
3. Remember, it always feels worse than it looks.
4. Take deep breaths and warm up. This will release endorphins, which naturally fight the adrenaline that causes anxiety.
5. Look the part. Dress to enhance confidence.
6. Channel your nervousness into positive energy and motivation.
7. Choose your literature, analyze it, and write your introduction early. Better content = higher confidence.
8. Practice and get feedback from a trusted source. (Don’t just practice for your cat.)
9. Visualize success through positive thinking.
10. Prepare, prepare, prepare! Practice is a performer’s best friend.

Essentially, the best way to work on easing any performance anxiety you feel is to gain practice and experience. Reading about these techniques in a textbook will get you part of the way, but the rest will need to come from embracing the old Nike motto. Remember when you learned how to ride a bike without training wheels as a kid? No one gave you a lecture on which you took notes, and you didn’t watch an instructional video. An adult likely gave you a push down the sidewalk, and you were left to your own devices to gain the balance and coordination to stay upright. With practice and experience and feedback from others, you will gain that confidence with oral interp as well.

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1.3: Vocal Elements of Performance

How many of you have attended an author's reading or listened to poets read online? Do you remember story time in elementary school? If you have seen these sorts of events, think of what made the reading enjoyable or made you wish you were somewhere else—anywhere else.

If we look at the characteristics that mark good literature readers, we frequently find these traits:

1. Confidence
2. Ample vocal volume
3. Appropriate pacing
4. Heightened inflection and cadence
5. Eyes off of page

In contrast, readers who bore the audience show the following traits:

1. Disinterested demeanor
2. Low vocal volume
3. Pacing too fast
4. Monotone voice
5. Eyes glued to page

The traits in the first list above are the bare minimum of what might make an interesting and compelling literature reading. In oral interpretation of literature, however, performers use their voice and body to take these things just a step further. An oral interpreter's goal is to amplify a central message or theme that is inherent in a literary text(s). To breathe life into the literature and ensure the audience is compelled to receive that central message, interpreter performers make ample use of their vocal and body language resources.

Whenever we are speaking or presenting to a group of people in the form of a speech, it becomes more important to use appropriate vocal characteristics and body language to enhance the effectiveness of our communication. When we present literature to an audience as opposed to a speech, it becomes even more critical to pay close attention to these elements so we can more accurately convey emotions, feelings, and nuance of characters/personae with literary texts.

You may also find that while taking this course, it will behoove you to become a “people watcher.” What better way to analyze and discover different ways of using voice and body than by watching others use them? Pay close attention to what actors do with characters in TV and movies to convey feeling, emotion, and personality. As you wait for the bus, keep your phone in your pocket and simply watch the people walking by. Observe the voices you hear, the posture you see, and how the whole package comes together to send you messages (sometimes intentional, sometimes not) about the people. Begin to play with these sorts of mannerisms as you prepare and present your own oral interpretation performances.

This chapter will explore the various resources at our disposal within our earthly vehicles (our bodies) that we can modify to effectively bring our chosen literature to life for our audiences. This use of voice and body to convey a message to others is often called “delivery.”

Voice

Our voices are truly one of the most flexible instruments we possess. Consider all the ways you can modify your voice in order to create feeling and amplify a message. As you learn to perform literature for your audience in oral interpretation, you can learn to play with these variations to add color, depth, and emotion to the personae you portray. These various modifications we can make to our vocal instruments are called “paralanguage,” the non-verbal aspects of voice. In other words, paralanguage refers to everything we can do with our voices independent of simply saying words.

Rate

This involves changes in the speed or tempo of our speech. Consider what it might communicate to someone if we speak at a rapid pace. What impression does that give to our listener? It might indicate we are in a hurry, stressed, or frustrated with the

conversation, just to name a few possibilities. In contrast, speaking at a slower pace could indicate we are trying to get an important point across, that we are having trouble forming our sentences, or that we aren't feeling well.

Volume

When we lower or raise our vocal volume, we change the decibel level of our voices. We could use a loud voice to indicate that a character or persona is angry, excited, or in a crowded location. A quiet voice or whisper could indicate shyness, youth or old age, or small stature.

Pitch/Intonation

Our voices come fully equipped with their own musical range, and even small changes in pitch or intonation using the musical scale of our voices can communicate many nuances of meaning to our audience members. If literature that you choose to perform includes a young boy character, you can raise your pitch a little to indicate his younger age. If your literature includes the character of a bear, you might lower your pitch significantly to demonstrate the bear's large and intimidating stature. You may even want to use a one-note monotone to display a persona's boredom or robotic qualities.

Enunciation

Enunciation involves the pronunciation of individual sounds within a word. Small changes in this can help a performer demonstrate where a particular character might be from or even his emotional or physical state.

You can indicate accents and dialects by using small changes in enunciation (and pronunciation, see next paragraph). Think of the way a Californian says the word "going" [GO-eeng] compared to someone who hails from Texas [GO-in]. In addition to the dropping of the last "g," the Texan employs more of a short "i" sound in the second syllable while the Californian uses more of a long "e" sound.

A performer might also decide to overemphasize all consonant sounds within a sentence or paragraph to show seriousness or a desire to be very clear with their words. Or, one may decide to purposely slur words of dialogue to illustrate a seriously inebriated character.

Pronunciation

Like enunciation, pronunciation deals with the way we say things. But, pronunciation refers to the sound of an entire word itself, and may also include the stress that is placed on particular syllables. Performers can use changes in pronunciation (like enunciation) to indicate origin of a persona. For example, the British typically say "adult" by placing the stress or emphasis on the first syllable [Ä-duhlt] while Americans place the stress on the second [a-DUHLT].

Consider how words like sherbet, picture, drawer, and button may all be pronounced differently depending on where someone is from. You can research and use different appropriate pronunciations to enhance the depth of your character portrayals.

Pauses

It is important to note the absence of voice as a valuable tool to add meaning and feeling to a performance. It is amazing how much "nothing" can say. Pauses can indicate time to think, nervousness, seriousness, shock, suspense, and more.

In addition to using pauses within performances, oral interpretation performers should also learn the value of pausing in the moments before beginning a performance (the time between arriving on a stage and beginning the first moments) as well as at the end (the time between the last performance moment and when a performer would walk off stage).

Special Vocal Characteristics

In addition to all the above, performers can use so many other marvelously effective techniques with their voices. You can play with resonance, letting your voice embrace deep, full sound or restrained sound depending on where you concentrate the air in your body (head, chest, throat). You can use nasal qualities, sending your voice into your nose on its way out of your body. You can use breathiness, allowing more air to escape from your mouth when you speak. You can use shakiness, giving your voice a bit of a warbly sound. There is so much more – stutters, lisps, onomatopoeia, sound effects. Often, these sorts of things can be called "vocalizations," sound effects we can make with our voices that don't necessarily involve words but that still add meaning to our

messages. What effects do you think these sorts of vocal changes would have on the meaning of your words? What personality characteristics or emotions might they evoke?

Variations in vocal characteristics are critical to engaging and meaningful oral interpretation performances. In speeches and formal, linear presentations, we are often told to use natural and conversational speech (clear articulation, adequate vocal volume, appropriate pronunciation, etc.) so that audience members may understand our words completely. In oral interp, however, we may purposely wish to violate these “norms” to better convey a character’s personality or amplify a message. Oral interp performers must learn to walk the line of using these techniques while still ensuring that their audience understands their words regardless of the choices they make in vocal variation throughout the performance.

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1.4: Body Language Elements of Performance

Our voices are only part of the performance equation. Your body language is also critical to the process and product. Your body language is the first element that audience members notice about you, before you even begin performing. Maintaining a command presence and total control over the way you use your body language can help you create much more effective performances.



Student, Hannah Anderson illustrating command performance while performing, Clovis Community College, 2016

There are many ways in which you can modify your body to create feeling and amplify a message.

Eye Contact and Focal Points

You've probably heard the expression that "the eyes are the windows to the soul." This sentence definitely rings true in an interp course. Your ability to connect to both the material and the audience with your eyes is likely the most valuable physical resource you can use in a performance.

In most other Communication courses that involve presentations, instructors will tell you to look at your audience when you present, and they emphasize the importance of eye contact. Rather than having you read an entire speech from notes or a manuscript, public speaking instructors say your goal should be to look at audience members more directly while glancing only occasionally at notes. In interpretation of literature, audiences also do not want to watch a performer stare at a text the entire time they perform as it does not allow them to become immersed in the performance. However, interp performers are not often expected to have an entire script memorized either. After all, the script is in their hands while they are performing. However, in interp, a performer's goal is not so much to always look at the audience but rather to direct eye gazes in the most appropriate direction for that moment of the performance, which may not always be at the audience. This is where analysis of a piece of literature becomes critical. For every section in a text and for every persona within it, an interper should understand TO WHOM that persona is speaking and direct eye gazes accordingly. These directions are known as focal points. There are four primary types: audience, inward, off-stage, and on-stage.

Focus on Audience

This is where the performer directs his gaze directly to audience members, bringing them directly into the performance (figure 1).

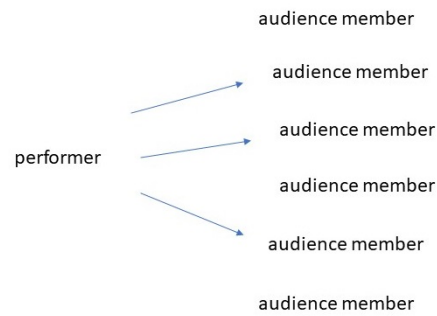


Figure 1.4.1: Performer gaze is directly upon audience members' faces during performance.

Performers usually use this form of focal points during introductions (when the performer is speaking as himself, introducing the piece and establishing its significance), but they also use it frequently when performing a prose story during narration lines. Performers may also choose to use this sort of focal point in expository sorts of literature, for example, when performing a section of an informative essay they wrote in college. Or, if a character in a story is addressing a large crowd, the performer can make the actual audience become the crowd in the story by looking directly at everyone present. Essentially, anytime you feel as though the persona speaking in a moment of your performance might be addressing the crowd as a whole, consider looking at your audience directly as you perform that portion.

Focus Off-Stage

Some literature typically chosen for interp performances include dialogue or moments where a persona (or personae) is (are) speaking to one other specific character or characters. In these moments, it might be confusing if the performer gazes at audience members while performing these lines. For example, if you are performing a bit of dialogue from Shakespeare's *Romeo and Juliet*, it might be awkward and confusing to audience members if you look at them during these lines. You can still immerse them in the literature and bring it to life, however, by establishing off-stage focal points for these characters. Whenever you say a line as Juliet, you might angle your eye gaze toward the back wall behind the audience, aimed slightly right. For Romeo, your eye gaze might also look at the back wall but aimed slightly left. Then, the audience sort of sits in the middle of this "conversation" you are having between the two characters (figure 2).

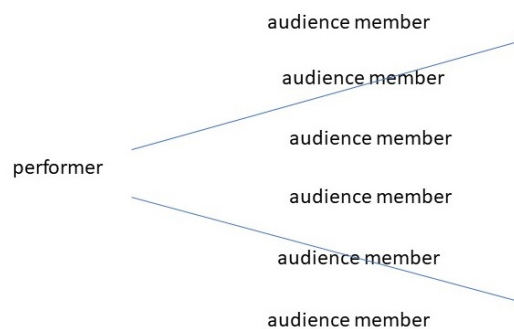


Figure 1.4.2: Performer gaze is over the top of audience members' heads at a more distant target during performance.

When these focal points pair with effective body language and vocal techniques, it will always be clear to your audience which character is speaking. You can also use off-stage focus when performing a monologue where a persona is speaking to one specific person, for example, a letter from a daughter to a mother.

Essentially, any time a persona within a piece of literature is speaking to a specific other or others, consider using off-stage focus.

Focus On-Stage

This sort of focus is not used often in interp, but it warrants mentioning as it is used (but sparingly) in group interp performances. This focus involves directing one's eye gaze to another persona on the same stage (figure 3).



Figure 1.4.3: Performer gaze is at other performers during performance.

This focus is often problematic in solo interp performances because if a performer is playing two or more characters, she must turn her body too far to the left or right to make it appear as though she is addressing a persona next to her. Therefore, solo performers are best advised to use a focus off-stage when establishing focal points for different characters.

In group interp performances, however, this sort of focus is more tempting and often feels more natural for performers. But while looking at their fellow group mates might feel more natural, group interp performers should use caution in choosing this sort of focus in any part of the performance as off-stage focus is considered by many interp enthusiasts to be a major differentiation between oral interpretation vs. plays/theatre/acting. Group performers will often look at one another in an introduction to their performance, but once the literature begins, you will mostly see them maintain an off-stage focus, even when the personae they are portraying are speaking to personae portrayed by another group mate.

Focus Inward

Sometimes, a persona is not speaking to any particular group of people or to any other individual present in the persona's same physical space. Examples of these types of personae might include one speaking in a diary entry or a character leaving a message on a voicemail. In these cases, a performer's gaze might not be on the audience or any particular point off-stage but rather everywhere and nowhere at once. Consider how one looks when talking to someone else on the phone. That person's eyes might gaze up or down or all around during the conversation. Or, think about where a character might look when talking to themselves or, perhaps, to their god. Again, it might be confusing to aim eye gazes at audience members during these lines, so directing a gaze at no particular spot (or all spots) while performing the literature might be best.

To establish effective focal points, you need to become familiar with the literature you are choosing to perform. This "familiarity" will allow you to take advantage of these focal point techniques to connect more to your audience and immerse them in your performance. While memorizing your script is fine, do not feel as though you must. You should aim to look up from your script somewhere around 75% of the time. No audience member wants to watch an interp performer stare at the text/script for the entire performance, and it will be much harder for the audience to see your great facial expressions and hear your voice in full if you stare down at a script the entire time. Become familiar with your text to allow you to break from staring at it, and use focal points effectively for a more immersive experience for your audience.

Facial Expressions

Many of us don't realize that we have almost 20 muscles in our faces that allow us to show a range of feelings and emotions. Even the subtlest of movements (often called micro expressions) can convey meaningful messages to those who perceive them. Think about what it might mean to someone if you frown at them when you are saying hello (as opposed to smiling at them). Consider how many times you've suspected someone was lying to you when their mouth kept twitching as they gave reasons for being late in meeting you for lunch.

It will add so much more meaning to your performance when you make conscious choices in facial expressions. For example, if a character is envious of another during a bit of dialogue you are performing, consider narrowing your eyes, furrowing your brows, and tightening your lips as you speak the character's lines to demonstrate this emotion to your audience. Or, as a third person narrator describes a disgusting stench coming from a nearby dumpster in a story, consider wrinkling up your nose and narrowing your eyes to communicate a feeling of disgust. Even if the material you are performing is somewhat expository/informative in nature rather than emotional, when your facial expressions "match" the vibe of the information you are sharing with your audience, it will make it easier and more pleasing for your audience to attend to your presentation.

Posture

The way we position our shoulders and torso in relation to our head and limbs sends messages to others. For example, if your professor walks into class with his shoulders hunched forward more so than usual, you might assume he injured his back or that he is tired. We can take advantage of this movement in our performances to create character and convey feelings.

If your literature includes a soldier persona, you might say that character's lines while erecting a stick-straight posture every time she has a line. If the narrator of a piece you are performing has a secret they'd like to share with the audience, they might lean forward a bit, maybe shifting one shoulder forward to create a barrier preventing another imaginary persona in the story from hearing the secret.



Student, Amanda Rodriguez, using different posture positions while performing, Clovis Community College, 2017

Hand Gestures

Using hand movement to convey meaning and feeling is a powerful tool for performers. Gestures can be used as symbols that signify or even substitute for particular words (e.g. an OK sign made with the hands), or they can be supplementary to words, adding feeling and meaning without actually standing for the words on their own (e.g. a palms up, hands out gesture while explaining something important).



Student, Jackie Lopez, using gestures while performing for kids, Clovis Community College, 2016

Hand gestures can also be particularly helpful when you need to establish physical differences between personae in a performance. For example, if a teacher is speaking to an uninterested student in a bit of dialogue, you might have the teacher often repeat a pointed-finger gesture as she speaks to the student. For the student, you might have her mime a phone in her hand by constantly doing a texting movement with your thumb.

Sometimes, beginning interp performers make the mistake of trying to use gestures to paint pictures of almost everything they say in a performance. This is not necessary and often results in a stilted appearance. If a specific gesture will help an audience understand a concept or feeling, you should probably use it. Otherwise, think of your hand movements more as accompaniments to your lines, similarly to what we do with our hands in normal conversation.

Movement

While hand gestures are the movements of your hands (and perhaps arms), movement refers to repositioning of the entire body. Typically, full-stage movement is minimal in solo interp performances. There is sometimes a bit more in group performance, but it still isn't quite as much as the way actors in a play might use an entire stage. Once again, full-stage movement is considered by interp enthusiasts to be a definitive factor separating stage plays from interp performance. That being said, you can use some movement to communicate meaning and feeling to your audience, and you can also use it to create transitions between literature pieces within one performance.

If a character dances in a piece of literature, you can feel free to use your space a bit to demonstrate this. If a character is dodging a bullet, it would be appropriate for you to jump to the side to show this. Be mindful, however, of trying to do too much movement in a performance. Since interp does not involve scenery, costumes, props, etc., literature that involves a lot of physical movement can be incredibly challenging to perform and often quite confusing for audiences to watch.

When performing bits from multiple pieces within one performance, a bit of movement can help show your audience when you are shifting out of one piece and into another. For example, you might set the script on the lectern and present your poem from there, but you might take your script and step in front of the lectern, closer to the audience to perform the prose piece that follows.

Attire

What we wear and how we adorn our bodies communicates messages. As stated before, costumes are not used in interp, but it is often a nice touch to dress honoring the mood/theme of a performance. When I was in high school, I performed excerpts of an anti-racism play entitled *God's Country*, by Stephen Dietz. I played multiple characters of various genders, races, and attitudes, and the message of the performance had dark and scary undertones. For every performance, I wore black shoes, black pants, a black turtleneck sweater, and pulled my hair back in a tight, low ponytail. I wanted to appear androgynous and wearing any sort of color felt like dishonor to the piece. It wasn't by any means a costume, but it allowed me to help set the mood of the piece for my audience before I had even said a word.

If you are performing a children's bedtime book, perhaps wear a comfortable pastel shirt with kittens on it. If you are performing a Christmas poem, you could wear red pants. Disneyland prohibits adult visitors from wearing costumes, so many people engage in something called "Disney bounding" where they dress in usual street clothes that have a similar color scheme and style that suggests their favorite Disney character. You can use this technique as inspiration to make purposeful choices in attire for your performances.



Figure 1.4.1: Student, Paige Staton, performing children's literature, Clovis Community College, 2015

Employing Vocals and Body Language

Many beginning performers have a hard time using these vocal and body language delivery resources more dynamically than they are accustomed to. This is where “play” from chapter 1 becomes critical. Give yourself permission to be “bigger” in your vocal characteristics and body language when you work in this course and practice at home.

As you learn which of the vocal and body language characteristics you might need to work on in your performances, consider using an old trick I used to employ during my high school competitive oral interpretation days. When you practice for an upcoming performance, go overboard with that particular characteristic. For example, if your peers and instructor have remarked that you could use more hand gestures in your presentations, move your hand(s) with every word you utter as you practice your performance. Don't worry about whether the movement makes sense at first, just move for movement's sake to get used to how it feels. You'll find that after doing this a time or two, using more natural gestures will begin to come more naturally. Similarly, if you have heard that you are monotone when you speak, try practicing the words while exploring every note in your musical range of inflection. Again, don't worry about the inflection making sense, just try almost “singing” the words. Of course, you would not employ these extreme techniques during an actual performance. However, going “bigger” in practice will help you break the ice and learn what it feels like to fully employ those elements, making it easier to pull back as needed in a performance.

As you learn to incorporate gestures into your performances, you may even want to write little side notes in your script/text to remind you when to do certain movements. As you gain in experience, using natural gestures will start to feel more natural to you.

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1.5: Literature for Performance

Defining Literature

Literature, in its broadest sense, is any written work. Etymologically, the term derives from the Latin *litaritura/litteratura*, “writing formed with letters,” although some definitions include spoken or sung texts. Taken to mean only written works, literature was first produced by some of the world’s earliest civilizations—those of Ancient Egypt and Sumeria—as early as the 4th millennium BC. Taken to include spoken or sung texts, it originated even earlier, and some of the first written works may have been based on a pre-existing oral tradition. As urban cultures and societies developed, there was a proliferation in the forms of literature. Developments in print technology allowed for literature to be distributed and experienced on an unprecedented scale, which has culminated in the twenty-first century in electronic literature.

References

“Poetry, N.”. *Oxford English Dictionary*. OUP. Retrieved 13 February 2014. (subscription required).

Preminger, *The New Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics*, 938–9.

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<https://milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/naming-the-unnameable/chapter/chapter-two-welcome-reader-reading-poetry/>.

Touchstones of Literary Merit

The label of “literature” can be placed on many different forms of the written word. While the term often conjures vision of Shakespearian plays or Homer’s *Odyssey*, those works are only examples of more specific categories of literature. For the purposes of oral interpretation, one might perform works such as those but may also choose to perform song lyrics, letters written by soldiers in World War II, or even text message exchanges between lovers. So, with so many possibilities, how does one go about choosing literature that would be good for performance?

Not all literature is a good fit for oral performance. Texts that make the best fit are those are of literary merit and that the criteria to determine that merit are as follows (Gura and Lee 2004).

Universality

If a value or idea is “universal,” this means that it is tangible to a wide audience. For a work of literature to have universality, it must have messages or themes to which many people can relate.

As an interper considers a piece of literature for performance, they should think about their audience and the sorts of topics that can be significant to them. For example, I might really love the poem, *Richard Cory*, by Edwin Arlington Robinson. However, this poem deals with the theme of suicide, which might not make it a good choice if I was performing for a younger audience or perhaps at a happy, celebratory event. However, perhaps Waddy Piper’s children’s book, *The Little Engine That Could*, about a little train engine who repeats the mantra, “I think I can, I think I can” to conquer a trek over a tall mountain could inspire a group of college students to continue their education. When evaluating literature for performance, look for themes you know you can connect to your audience.

Individuality

While you want to find universal themes for your audience so they can relate to the literature, you also want to ensure you aren’t simply selecting works that might be overworked or overdone. Audiences love relating to pieces, but they also appreciate novelty. The literature you choose to perform should be unique in some way. This can be through language/style, or perhaps through the characters in the piece, or maybe in the way the author tells a story, etc.

This is not to say that performers should steer clear of classic or popular literature known by many. However, if you do choose to perform a work with which your audience is very familiar, ensure that you infuse it with uniqueness that can make it appeal to your audience. If you choose to perform a scene from a recent popular movie, for example, do not feel you have to imitate the characters

as they appeared in the film. This approach, unless you are a gifted impressionist, can be disconcerting to an audience. Analyze the literature, discover what it speaks to you, think about the attitude and feelings of the characters, independent from any previous conceptions you had about the work. Allow yourself to view it through a different lens before making performance choices.

It can be the “easy choice” to search for literature with which you are already familiar for an oral interpretation performance. However, spend some time looking for work that is new to you and to your audience. Performing literature is a wonderful way to expose ourselves and our audience to material we might not otherwise encounter. Take advantage of this opportunity.

Essentially, when performing oral interpretation, aim to present your audience with literature and/or an approach to it that they’ve never seen before.

Significance

Perhaps the most important of Gura and Lee’s touchstones is that of significance. Literature with significance has impact beyond its own existence. It makes the reader, performer, and audience think and make connections to their own lives and/or the world. Have you ever seen a movie that you could not stop talking about for weeks? Ever had an amazingly easy time writing an essay about a poem in an English class because you had so much to say about it? Then, you have encountered literary significance.

I once had a student who chose to perform a series of silly poems from a children’s book about going back to school. He performed them very morosely, darkly, highlighting themes adults could connect to as they identify the drudgery of tasks they do every day. I loved that way it made me reconsider the sorts of daily chores I find boring that I remember being enamored with as a child. It gave me an appreciation for the fact that I can do them at all, and this wasn’t something the student pointed out directly. I found this connection through watching the performance and comparing it to my own experiences.

If you choose works that speak to your audience, you make their experience watching you perform more meaningful. It is also easier to choose universal themes and ideas to highlight for your audience through your performance when you choose literature with significance.

Many students in an oral interpretation course are authors in their own rights. You may have some poems you have written as a hobby, or maybe you wrote an interesting essay or creative non-fiction story in previous course. You can and should absolutely consider using your own work. Be sure to take a fresh look at it and measure it against the touchstones described above to help you decide whether you would like to use it.

References

Gura, Timothy. and Charlotte Lee. Oral Interpretation. 11th ed. Routledge. 2004.

Genres

Categorically, literature can be classified according to whether it is fiction or non-fiction and whether it is poetry or prose or drama. It can be further distinguished according to major forms such as the novel, short story, or essay, and works are often categorized according to historical periods or their adherence to certain aesthetic features or expectations.

When performing literature from different genres, there is different preparatory “work” that must go into the analysis of the literature. As you know, picking up a book of fiction is different than opening a book of nonfiction essays. When we do so, there is an ever-so-slight, yet important and different preparation. Think about it. Although both nonfiction and fiction share similar writing tropes, how would you feel if someone told you that the nonfiction book you are reading—the one that brought you to tears—is not nonfiction, but fiction? Most people would become upset, feeling as though they had been duped. To put it another way, think about how differently you prepare to engage as an audience member at a live performance depending on its genre. How do you set yourself up differently for a stand-up comic as opposed to an opera? Not only are the effects of the performance different, but the way we emotionally prepare ourselves to receive them is also different.

An oral interpretation performer should understand to what genre a work belongs before performing it. That will help the performer determine how to best gauge its meaning, understand its characters, and make performance choices. Literature studies courses often describe several genres, however for the sake of oral interpretation, we will focus on three primary ones: poetry, prose, and drama.

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References

“Poetry, N.”. *Oxford English Dictionary*. OUP. Retrieved 13 February 2014. (subscription required).

Preminger, *The New Princeton Encyclopedia of Poetry and Poetics*, 938–9.

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<https://milnepublishing.geneseo.edu/naming-the-unnameable/chapter/chapter-two-welcome-reader-reading-poetry/>.

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1.6: The Poetry Genre

Definition

Poetry is a form of literary art that uses aesthetic and rhythmic qualities of language to evoke meanings in addition to, or in place of, prosaic ostensible meaning (ordinary intended meaning). Poetry has traditionally been distinguished from prose by its being set in verse. Additionally, prose is cast in sentences while poetry is in lines, and the syntax of prose is dictated by meaning, whereas that of poetry is held across meter or the visual aspects of the poem.

While poetry sometimes rhymes, it does not always. It is the rhythmic pattern of words that sets it apart from the natural speech of the other genres. However, poems also place particular emphasis on figurative language, symbolism, and abstractions. This is often the characteristic that either draws fans to poetry or deters those from wanting to study it. Meaning is often indirect in a poem, putting much responsibility on the reader to analyze and decipher the various nuances of feeling and meaning with it.

One way to better understand poetry is by analyzing the elements that make up a good poem. Poems are written in either closed or open form. Closed form poems are written in specific patterns, using meter, line length, and line groupings called stanzas. Open form poems, often still referred to as "free verse" poems, do not use regular rhythmic patterns (i.e., metric feet), are usually unrhymed, have varying line lengths, and have no set line groupings. As you analyze a poem for an oral interpretation performance, remember that you are looking for relationships between the formal devices of poetry, like word choice, metric pattern, metaphor, and the poem's subject. A thorough investigation of the elements of a poem helps you to better understand the poem.

Analyzing Poetry

Muriel Rukeyser says in *The Life of Poetry* that to successfully read a poem, we must give a poem "a total response." This means giving it all our attention, taking it in slowly, reading it several times. It means listening to the poem openly, without judgment, and without projecting our own assumed meanings onto it. Instead, Rukeyser writes, it means coming "to the emotional meanings at every moment." As she explains, "That is one reason for the high concentration of music, in poetry."

To come to emotional meanings at every moment means to adjust and react to the way a poem takes shape with every word, every line, every sentence, every stanza. Each poem creates its own universe as it moves from line to line. It is a universe that Rukeyser describes as the "universe of emotional truth." So how exactly does one listen with his or her emotions?

Reading creates an indirect, yet intimate, connection between reader and author. As readers, we take the author's words—their breath—into ourselves. We shape the words with our own bodies and, too, give them life with our own breath. Reading poetry, we breathe in what a poet breathes out. We share breath. The words and their meanings become part of our body as they move through our mind, triggering sensations in our bodies that lead to thoughts. And through this process, we have experiences that are new and that change us as much as any other experience can.

Poetry is a condensed art form that produces an experience in a reader through words. And though words may appear visually as symbols on the page, the experience that poems produce in us is much more physical and direct. The elements of poetry permit a poet to control many aspects of language—tone, pace, rhythm, sound—as well as language's effects: images, ideas, sensations. These elements give power to the poet to shape a reader's physical, emotional, intellectual, and spiritual experience of the poem. Because form and function are so closely intertwined, it is impossible to paraphrase a poem. This is why we must read poems with full concentration and focus more than once. It is why we must read them out loud. It is why we must be attentive to every aspect of the poem on both ends: as a writer, and as a reader.

Readers come to the page with different backgrounds and a range of different experiences with poetry, but it is how we read a poem that determines our experience of it. "Reading" or even "analyzing" a poem may not be the best description of this process. Instead, one who plans to perform a poem must go through the actual process of "coming to" the poem, ingesting its lines, and responding emotionally.

Consider the following poem by Emily Dickinson:

I 'M nobody! Who are you?
Are you nobody, too?

Then there's a pair of us—don't tell!
They'd banish us, you know.
How dreary to be somebody!
How public, like a frog
To tell your name the livelong day
To an admiring bog!

Upon first read of this poem, one might conclude the speaker is thankful she is not popular and well known by others. However, after further analysis, it is possible that this speaker truly does wish to be part of the in-crowd. Perhaps she is trying to impress or identify with the person to whom she is speaking by saying these things while she secretly wishes to be one of the popular people. You can see how the interpretation one chooses for this poem would affect the way one would say the words, use pauses, and select appropriate facial expressions.

Performance of Poetry

Since poetry can vary in its levels of abstraction, some find it frustrating to read since meaning is often connotative and indirect. This can make it difficult to decide how to perform it and adequately assign meaning to its words with our delivery. However, an oral interpreter of poetry must thoroughly understand a poem to honor it properly and convey each nuance of its meaning and feeling. For example, a performer could not decide where the narrator should gaze if she hasn't thought about to whom the narrator is speaking. If a performer has not considered the emotions or motivations behind the narrator's words in a poem, he will not be able to use appropriate facial expressions, posture, or vocal inflection.

You may find the following considerations helpful as they provide characteristics to look for when analyzing poetry. You can use the answers to these prompts to help you make decisions on how to choose themes/messages to highlight in a performance. They will also help you make performance choices on how to use your voice and body to perform a poem for your audience:

Determine the Subject of the Poem

- Paraphrase/summarize the poem: what is it about?
- Does the poem address a social, psychological, historical, or mythical phenomenon?

Identify the Poem's Narrator

- Who is speaking? Consider age, gender, occupation, and more.
- To whom?
- Under what circumstances? Identify the setting.

Identify the Narrator's Audience

- To whom is the narrator speaking?
- Is the narrator speaking to him or herself? If not, is that audience in the same physical space as the narrator? Is the audience a single person, multiple people?

Note the Diction (Word Choice) of the Poet

- Be sure to look up all unfamiliar words in a dictionary.
- What are the words' denotations and connotations?
- Are the words concrete or abstract?

Determine the Tone of the Poem

- Is the poem serious? Ironic? Satiric? Contemplative? Ambiguous?
- Identify words that set the tone.
- Determine whether the tone changes within the poem.

Determine the Rhythmical Devices Used by the Poet

- What is the basic metrical pattern? Line length?
- What is the length of the stanza?
- What is the rhyme scheme? End rhyme? Internal rhyme?
- Does the poet employ any other metrical devices?
- What form does the poem take? Open or closed?

Note Your Emotional Response to the Poem

- How does the poem make you feel?
- How might you convey those emotions and feelings to an audience using your voice and body language?

Note the Use of Other Literary Devices

- What allusions (indirect references) does the poem contain?
- Listen to the sounds in the poem. Make note of characteristics such as assonance, alliteration, and onomatopoeia.
- Is there any figurative language such as metaphor, simile, symbolism, imagery, irony, personification, antithesis, hyperbole, metonymy, synecdoche, allegory, paradox, understatement, or overstatement?
- Note the use or absence of punctuation.
- Titles are important in poetry. What does the title say about the work?

Determine the Values of the Poem

- Does the poet succeed in recreating his experiences within the reader? How?
- Is the experience intensely felt by the reader?

Perhaps the most challenging part of performing poetry, particularly those poems that rhyme, is making it sound natural. When a performer gets caught up in overly emphasizing the rhyme of a piece, it can sound unnatural, mechanical, and it tends to detract from the meaning. To prevent this from happening, you might consider physically rewriting the poem, reflecting the natural pausing spots you would like to take during performance. For example, take a look at the original written format of a monologue delivered by King Henry V from William Shakespeare's play, *Henry V*:

Henry V, Act III, Scene I, by William Shakespeare

(Appearing here as typed in the original Shakespearian work)

Once more unto the breach, dear friends, once more,

Or close the wall up with our English dead!

In peace there's nothing so becomes a man

As modest stillness and humility,

But when the blast of war blows in our ears,

Then imitate the action of the tiger:

Stiffen the sinews, summon up the blood,

Disguise fair nature with hard-favored rage,

Now set the teeth and stretch the nostril wide,

Hold hard the breath and bend up every spirit

To his full height. On, on, you noblest English,

Dishonor not your mothers. Now attest

That those whom you called fathers did beget you.

*Be copy now to men of grosser blood,
And teach them how to war. And you, good yeoman,
Whose limbs were made in England, show us here
The mettle of your pasture. Let us swear
That you are worth your breeding, which I doubt not,
For there is none of you so mean and base
That hath not noble luster in your eyes.
I see you stand like greyhounds in the slips,
Straining upon the start. The game's afoot.
Follow your spirit, and upon this charge
Cry "God for Harry, England, and Saint George!"*

Shakespeare, W., Kellogg, B., ed. (1883) *Shakespeare's King Henry V*. New York, Clark & Maynard. [Pdf] Retrieved from the Library of Congress, <https://www.loc.gov/item/15016808/>.

The above is written in a rhythm known as iambic pentameter. A review of the poem reveals that the natural stopping point for some of the sentences/phrases don't always land at the ends of the poems "lines." For example, in the line "Hold hard the breath and bend up every spirit To his full height," the line ends visually after "spirit," but the essence of the sentence's meaning only shines when the phrasing is continued through the word "height." So, a performer would likely want to take care not to pause between the words "spirit" and "To" but rather after the word "height."

Therefore, when performing poetry, a performer might consider rewriting the poem structurally (without changing the words) to better reflect how it might look if the character spoke the words as natural speech:

Henry V, Act III, Scene I, by William Shakespeare

(Appearing here in a re-typed/re-formatted version that reflects more natural phrasing)

*Once more unto the breach, dear friends, once more -- or close the wall up with our
English dead!*

In peace there's nothing so becomes a man as modest stillness and humility.

But when the blast of war blows in our ears, then imitate the action of the tiger:

Stiffen the sinews, summon up the blood,

Disguise fair nature with hard-favored rage,

Now set the teeth and stretch the nostril wide.

Hold hard the breath and bend up every spirit to his full height.

On, on, you noblest English,

Dishonor not your mothers. Now attest that those whom you called fathers did beget you.

Be copy now to men of grosser blood, and teach them how to war.

And you, good yeoman, whose limbs were made in England,

Show us here the mettle of your pasture.

*Let us swear that you are worth your breeding, which I doubt not, for there is none of you
so mean and base that hath not noble luster in your eyes.*

I see you stand like greyhounds in the slips, straining upon the start.

The game's afoot.

*Follow your spirit, and upon this charge cry "God for Harry, England,
....and Saint George!"*

Note that the above, though it has the identical wording as the previous version, looks a bit more like a prose piece since the lines no longer seem to reveal an obvious rhythm/pattern. After analyzing a poem, consider rewriting it to reflect the phrasings and meanings more naturally. This may help you avoid falling into a sing-songy, unnatural delivery style and help your audience to understand the meaning of the poem more deeply.

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1.7: The Prose Genre

Definition

Prose is a form of language that possesses ordinary syntax and natural speech rather than rhythmic structure; in which regard, along with its measurement in sentences rather than lines, it differs from poetry. Compared to poetry, prose sounds more like natural, every day speech.

While prose can certainly include some figurative language and connotative meanings, the messages are usually more direct. Prose often includes the voice of a primary narrator who either is (first person) or is not (third person) involved directly with the characters and plot of the work and who often explains context, action, and character descriptions to the reader.

Examples of prose include (but are not limited to) novels, short stories, essays, letters, speeches, diary entries, research articles, webpages, textbooks, newspaper stories, etc. What you are reading right now is considered a form of prose. Additionally, works such as Martin Luther King Jr.'s *I Have a Dream* speech, the novel *War and Peace* by Leo Tolstoy, an article on the Cincinnati Bengals football team in *ESPN* magazine, the letter you may have written to Santa as a kid, and my creative non-fiction essay on apartment life that I wrote in college are also all examples of prose.

Writing Style and Language

You can use the prose author's writing style to help you analyze and understand the work as well as to help you make delivery decisions. Writing style reflects the author's attitudes toward the subject matter, and it should influence your performance. Your goal as an oral interp performer is to match the style of performance with the style of writing. The style of prose is determined by things like diction, imagery, figurative language, and syntax. Below are clues to identifying the style of a piece that can help you make decisions on how to convey meaning through your voice and body when you perform prose.

Connotative vs. Denotative Words

Some words contain richer meaning than what one may glean from simply a dictionary definition. For example, a general word such as "home" is more likely to have connotative value conjuring more feeling than specific language such as "house," which describes a type of building. These feelings will also vary among different people depending upon one's culture, past experiences, etc.

Genre of Discourse

Prose performers must decide how words are used that indicate the kind of style the writer is trying to convey. For example, "commit homicide," "blow away," and "murder" all mean to kill someone. They come from legal discourse, vocal slang, and everyday usage. However, "blow away" and "murder" each carry a distinct connotative and emotive value. Also, "happen," "occur," "manifest," and "go down" are similar in meaning but come from distinct genres of discourse: everyday usage (happen), formal usage (occur), philosophical discourse (manifest), and slang (go down). "Happen" and "go down" could be used in everyday speech; "occur" and "manifest," being more formal, would not ordinarily be used in speech.

Allusions, Similes, and Metaphors

A writer's use of these is an important aspect of literary style. All three can be used to convey connotative meaning.

- Allusions refer to shared experiences many would understand. Example: "I hope tonight won't be another Thanksgiving dinner."
- Similes describe things using a comparison that employs the words "like" or "as." Example: "I feel like a million dollars now!"
- Metaphors draw a comparison by equating two or more things that are generally unrelated as the same. For example, "He has a heart of stone" or "She's a real piece of work."

Syntax

This includes punctuation and how words are grouped together demonstrating their relationship and importance. Your discoveries here will dictate your use of vocal elements such as pauses, rate, emphasis, volume, and inflection.

Short, simple sentences indicate a direct approach and suggest immediacy of experience. Long, complicated sentences suggest a more sophisticated and evaluative approach. Examples of punctuation may include:

- Semicolon – marks a turn of thought or definite separation between two aspects of the same thought; and usually requires a slight pause.
- Parentheses and double dash – mark off distinct speech phrases.
- Single dash or colon – often marks the pause that occurs just before a summary and implies a reference to some previous portion.

All of this being said, use punctuation as a guide but not a rule. It is more for the eye than for the ear. A comma in a text does not always demand a pause. Keep in mind that how you perform punctuation might change as you begin practicing a piece for presentation.

Poetic diction

Poetic language, generally connotative, would stand out in casual conversation, so an author's choice to include it in a prose piece would be very intentional. Unusual connotations also carry with them double meanings. For instance, the word "terrific" can be used for its connotation of terrifying; the word "taxation" for its connotation of "taxing" or stress-inducing. Consider words such as "escape" vs. "flee," "girl" vs. "maiden," and "invisible" vs. "unseen." In each of these pairings, the first usage is essentially descriptive; the latter more poetic or emotive.

The sounds of words an author has chosen are especially important for the interpreter. The sounds of the words carry meaning as well as the word itself. Pace and vocal quality are influenced by the connotative meaning of words.

Performance of Prose

Since prose is written in a style most like our natural speech, it is often the first genre you may tackle in your adventure through the world of oral interpretation.

Sometimes, a work of prose is more expository in nature rather than narrative (telling a story), focused on providing information or developing an argument as opposed to developing a plot. A narrative prose piece, on the other hand, tells a story from a first- or third-person narrator's point of view. A performer of prose should understand the author's intention behind the style of the work. The performer should thoroughly analyze the narrator or primary voice of the work to choose a performance approach that honors that voice's point of view, personality, biases, feelings, etc.

Particularly in narrative prose, you will sometimes see more than one persona represented in the work. These may exist in the form of character dialogue throughout the piece. As a prose performer, you must examine these characters and determine how to perform them in a way that makes them distinct from the primary voice (narrator). You can do this using the various vocal and body language elements discussed in chapters 3 and 4. All characters should have some sort of body and/or vocal change that works with the interpretation given to that character. It can be your stance, how you hold your shoulders/head/posture, specific gestures to that character, or an accent or higher vocal tone. Do not go overboard, this should be subtle. Most importantly, be consistent with these choices, doing them each time the character speaks so as not to confuse your audience. Consider the following to add depth to your characterizations:

- Feel free to commit to an emotion that the character experiences.
- Consider adding reaction moments even when characters do not have anything to say. Characters can react whether they speak or not.
- Control your body. Avoid nervous rocking back and forth or nervous twitches such as wiggling your foot or playing with your pant leg.
- Use facial expressions. Your face should be "alive" at all times. Every narrator's/character's facial expressions should be appropriate for that character. Practicing in front of a mirror can help.
- Use appropriate focal points (see chapter 4 in Body Language). If you determine through analysis that the narrator or primary voice is speaking to a group of people, engage the audience with eye contact using an audience focal point. Use the layout of classroom to your advantage, scanning and picking individuals to look at for an extended time during specified intense moments add to the performance. Though, if you determine whether the primary voice is speaking to no one in particular, perhaps rather to his or herself, you may need to use the inner-expressed focal point, looking into space as one may do while

talking on the phone. When interpreting character dialogue, use different off-stage focal points to indicate characters looking at one another while speaking.

- Use appropriate vocal characteristics for the various personae. Play with tone, rhythm, volume, and all forms of dynamics. The secret with vocals is variation, and this can help make your various personae in a piece more distinct.
- Get to know the personae of the piece beyond the words in the literature. For deeper characterization, consider the possible history, backstories, and the relationships that exist between the characters and voices of the prose. Most of the time, these conclusions will be drawn simply from your own understanding and assumptions. That is fine. You can use those to help you make performance and delivery decisions for characterization.

Often, a prose piece may be too long for you to perform it in its entirety, and you will have to make a “cutting.” This involves selecting a chunk(s) from the entire work that still fit within the theme or message the performer is aiming to convey to the audience to include within a performance. Later, this chapter addresses cutting literature for performance, but in short, it works best to select large chunks for performance rather than piecing small lines and segments together to preserve as much of the rhythm and flow of an author’s words as possible. One key exception to this might be in the cutting of “tag lines,” or the short bits of narration after a line of dialogue. These are phrases such as “he said,” “she shouted angrily,” or “they paused.” Since performers are using character vocalizations to bring literature to life for audiences, they will likely be **DOING** the actions indicated in these tag lines (e.g. shouting angrily or pausing). Including them when performing often seems unnecessary, and many interpreters choose to omit them in performance.

Any fiction or non-fiction novel, essay, journal, or short story can be selected to be cut for a prose performance. The use of diction, facial expressions, gestures, eye contact, intonation, pace and other elements of delivery will offer a rewarding experience for both interpreter and audience. Every delivery choice made for prose should benefit the piece, help tell the story or convey the information, and aid interpretation. Performing prose effectively, particularly a narrative piece with several characters, takes lots of practice, devotion, and creativity. The more work you have done analyzing the work and understanding it, the better you can bring the piece to light for your audience. Strive to convey the crisp mental imagery you had when you read it when you perform for your audience.

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1.8: The Drama Genre

Definition

The first thing people usually think of when hearing the word “drama” is a script of a sad emotional nature. The next thing that comes to mind is something like a “drama queen,” someone known to blow any minor inconvenience out of proportion or create extreme emotions where none need to exist. However, drama has a much more specific meaning in the arena of literary genres.

Drama is any literature in the form of a script. These scripts can be sad, humorous, satirical, historical, and more (or all the above). This means that while movie/television scripts and plays fall within the drama genre, so can things like text message exchanges and interview or court transcripts.

Like prose, the verbiage in drama is typically that of natural speech. However, unlike prose, there is not typically a narrator. Instead, the characters in the drama speak for themselves and reveal their personalities and the plot of the script through their own words and actions. Additionally, while prose is often written in past tense (though not always), works of drama happen in the present.

Drama literature is written in script form. Instead of being organized in chapters like prose, drama exists in scenes and acts. Instead of sentences being organized into stanzas (like poetry) or paragraphs (like prose), drama exists in the form of lines and character dialogue. Often, there will be stage directions in brackets throughout the script indicating what characters are supposed to do on stage.

Here is an example of how literature from the drama genre appears (from the screenplay from *Steel Magnolias* by Robert Harling:

Annelle: Sammy Wayne Desoto, what is this in my Frigidaire?

Sammy: Beer.

Annelle: I don't care what you do with your refrigerator, but you will not keep liquor in mine.

[dumps the beer out in the yard]

Sammy: Oh, Annelle, for Christ's sake!

Annelle: Who? Who did you say?

Sammy: Christ, Christ, Christ!

Annelle: Are you speaking of our Lord? Is that whose name you're taking in vain?

Sammy: That's the one.

Annelle: Well, I'm sorry, Sammy. But I am not about to spend the next fifty years of my life with someone I'm not gonna run into in the hereafter.

Sammy: Oh, Annelle, goddammit!

Annelle: I think we should pray.

Sammy: I'd rather eat dirt!

Performance of Drama

One of the first challenges to using drama in oral interpretation is selecting a piece. It is tempting to many beginners in oral interpretation to use a script from a popular movie scene or television show because it is familiar to them. However, literature that is popular with the masses may not always be the best fit for oral interpretation because audience members familiar with the work already have expectations in their minds of what the characters should be like. If the performer deviates from those expectations,

the audience is often disappointed or thinks the performer is simply imitating something that has already been done. So, challenge yourself to find unique and compelling pieces with which the audience may not already be familiar.

You can use the following standards when selecting a drama piece for an oral interp performance:

1. Do you identify with the main character, theme, conflict?
2. Can you envision yourself portraying the main character (voice, face, body)?
3. Will the audience be somehow moved by the main character(s)? Will they care about their conflict?
4. Does the language of the script engage you as a reader?
5. Is there a wide variety of levels with which build to the climax or shape of the performance?
6. Does the ending leave us with a strong resolution?

Since character is so critical in drama, aim to give detail and depth to each character you emulate in a dramatic interpretation. There is no narrator present to describe the setting and reveal character feelings, relationships to others, and backstories, so the words and lines from the characters themselves are critical to the entire piece. A performer must carefully analyze the characters of a drama script and show the depth of those characters through carefully controlled physical mannerisms of the voice and body, and it is crucial that these characters are consistent and distinct throughout the performance so that the audience can discern between them. For example, you may choose to slow down the voice of an old man (rate), while a cheerleader character may speak with a louder-than-usual volume. For a talking pig character, you may bend over significantly at the waist (posture) while a young child character would be constantly wiggling her feet (movement). When selecting a work of drama for performance, interpers should choose pieces with a manageable number of characters for their skill level. The characters' nonverbal mannerisms should be unique, and focal points should be used to add further distinction to these characterizations. If a work has more than a few characters, it may become too difficult for a performer to communicate the differences between them.

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1.9: Cutting and Organizing Literature for Performance

Cutting

Sometimes, you will find a work of literature that is suitable for performance that fits nicely within time requirements you have been given for the presentation. This is not always the case, however. Many times, particularly with prose or drama, a piece you desire to use is too long for performance and requires you to make what is called a “cutting” to perform it.

A cutting of literature is a chunk or segment of the larger work or multiple segments of the work strung together. When cutting literature, a performer should consider several factors in addition to the general expectations of the performance such as the message/theme of the performance, audience interest and expectations, the number of characters that must be performed in the work, and whether the performer will need to provide background information in the introduction to give context and aid understanding.

When cutting a single work of literature, the cut piece should have a clear beginning, middle, and end. You may find it helpful to find your desired ending point and cut the rest of the work that you feel leads nicely up to that point. Your cutting should also demonstrate part of the conflict of the piece, though not necessarily resolution. It simply helps the interest, feel, and momentum of the performance when something happens in the literature to move the cutting forward.

While you are cutting, consider the basic elements of dramatic structure. The term “dramatic structure” refers to the parts into which a short story, a novel, a play, a screenplay, or a narrative poem can be divided.

Aristotle divided drama into three parts: a beginning, a middle, and an end. Perhaps equally influential to writers and literary critics alike has been Gustav Freytag’s analysis of dramatic structure (figure 4). Although Freytag’s work is based on the structure of ancient Greek and Shakespearean five-act plays, it can be applied to works of prose (and longer works of poetry) as well. Freytag posited that plots are divided into five parts or acts:

1. Exposition - introduction of characters, setting, etc.
 - In the exposition, the background information that is needed to understand the story properly is provided. Such information includes the protagonist, the antagonist, the basic conflict, the setting, and so forth.
 - The exposition ends with the inciting moment, which is the single incident in the story's action without which there would be no story. The inciting moment sets the remainder of the story in motion beginning with the second act, the rising action.
2. Conflict and rising action - the issue is discovered, and problems arise due to the conflict.
 - During the rising action, the basic conflict is complicated by the introduction of related secondary conflicts, including various obstacles that frustrate the protagonist's attempt to reach his or her goal. Secondary conflicts can include adversaries of lesser importance than the story's antagonist, who may work with the antagonist or separately, by and for themselves.
3. Climax (turning point) - the height of conflict and highest tension; everything is unleashed.
 - In the climax, or turning point, there marks a change, for the better or the worse, in the protagonist's affairs. If the story is a comedy, things will have gone badly for the protagonist up to this point; now, the tide, so to speak, will turn, and things will begin to go well for him or her. If the story is a tragedy, the opposite situation will ensue, with things going from good to bad for the protagonist.
4. Falling action - events settle down and a solution is sought.
 - During the falling action, the conflict between the protagonist and the antagonist unravels, with the protagonist winning or losing against the antagonist. The falling action may contain a moment of final suspense, during which the outcome of the conflict is in doubt.
5. Dénouement or catastrophe (depending upon whether the literature is a comedy or a tragedy) - the resolution/conclusion; things come to an end happily (or not).
 - The comedy ends with a denouement in which the protagonist is better off than he or she was at the story's outset. The tragedy ends with a catastrophe in which the protagonist is worse off than he or she was at the beginning of the narrative.

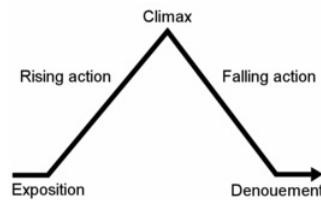


Figure 4: The five parts of *Freytag's pyramid*

Organizing your cutting around the spirit of Freytag's five elements will help move the plot along in your performance and keep the audience involved. If your author tells the story in a non-linear fashion (e.g. through flashbacks or in reverse) try your best to craft a cutting that mirrors the structure they have created.

You will see the elements above in many works of prose and drama and sometimes in poetry, mostly within pieces that tell a story. However, works that do not include these elements should not necessarily be discounted. But, since the plot structure elements add interest and variety to an oral interp performance, you should find ways to create the spirit of these elements in whatever pieces you choose.

Should you find a piece that seems lacking in one of more of the plot structure elements, you can sometimes find ways to use your voice and body to create the same sorts of feelings that accompany some of the elements. For example, [here I will provide an example of a poem from OER material and walk through how voice/body can be used to create build even when the poem does not tell a story.

One method you might find helpful in cutting a literature selection is the Cha Cha Cha Method:

1. CHUNK it. Find the various selections of your piece that give brief plot synopsis of the work, then name each section (one to two words only).
2. CHUCK it. Throw out sections that you don't like. Don't worry about sections which may be important to the plot at this point. You may realize that you don't like the piece as much as you thought you did and opt to choose something different.
3. CHOOSE it. These are the most vital moments of your piece:
 1. This section will be the first part of the literature that you present to us. You can place it right before your self-authored introduction or right afterward. It should get the audience's attention to set the mood. It may likely also introduce us to the main character(s).
 2. Choose the section that includes the building of intensity, perhaps the moment where the reader/audience is breathless as the events take place.
 3. It is likely that the message of your piece will appear (directly or indirectly) in this section. This is the ending that should have an impact on the audience somehow (e.g. provides hope, foreshadows dark times, resolves in tragedy, etc.). Your last line should be memorable and let the audience feel the emotion of the program.
4. CHUM it. This section is the rising action which builds to the conflict. It should lead into the climax smoothly, so be aware of its "shape." This section will likely make the audience like or identify with the main character/narrator. It is helpful when each piece of rising action is at a different emotional level and creates engagement with variety.
5. CHIP it. These are "trimming cuts" or the cutting of specific lines and words. This step should help to maintain the balance of each section. It can be the most difficult and painful step, and you should do it soon in the cutting process before you get too attached to the material.
6. CHECK it. Time your performance. It is better to be short than long, as you can always add segments back into the cutting. Use time to determine the "shape" of your cutting – find a balance.
7. CHEAT it. Sometimes, in order to make two segments "fit" back-to-back in your performance or to add context or clarity, you might need to add very brief lines. These lines can help your cutting make sense or flow better. This should be done very sparingly and with absolute caution, however, to preserve author intent and to honor the spirit of the piece.

If you are having difficulties (e.g. the work is still too long), rethink your cutting. Is there any segment you left in the piece that has no real reason for being there? Is it necessary? If the audience does not need to know it, then cut that bit. Cuttings are organic and changing. You can always adjust them.

You may occasionally find that a piece of literature is too short to fill performance time, and if that is the case, you can often arrange multiple pieces of literature together around a similar theme.

Attributions

Organizing

Oral interpretation of literature presents a performer with marvelous potential. Because the art of oral interp is not typically tied to costumes, props, scenery, and lighting (as would be the case in a play or movie), there is room for much flexibility in the sorts of literature the performer can present to an audience. A performer need not only perform one piece of literature. In fact, it is common for an oral interpretation program to include multiple pieces that all center around a particular theme, concept, message, lesson, or thesis. One can use the cutting advice from the previous section of this chapter to take segments from various works of literature to create a performance program.

Of course, this sort of interpretation program may put further demand on the performer in voice and body to ensure the works of literature and personae within them are distinct. But, when the performer fully understands the theme of the program, has analyzed and fully understands each work included, and gives careful thought and practice to vocal and body language delivery choices, the effect can be rewarding for audience and performer.

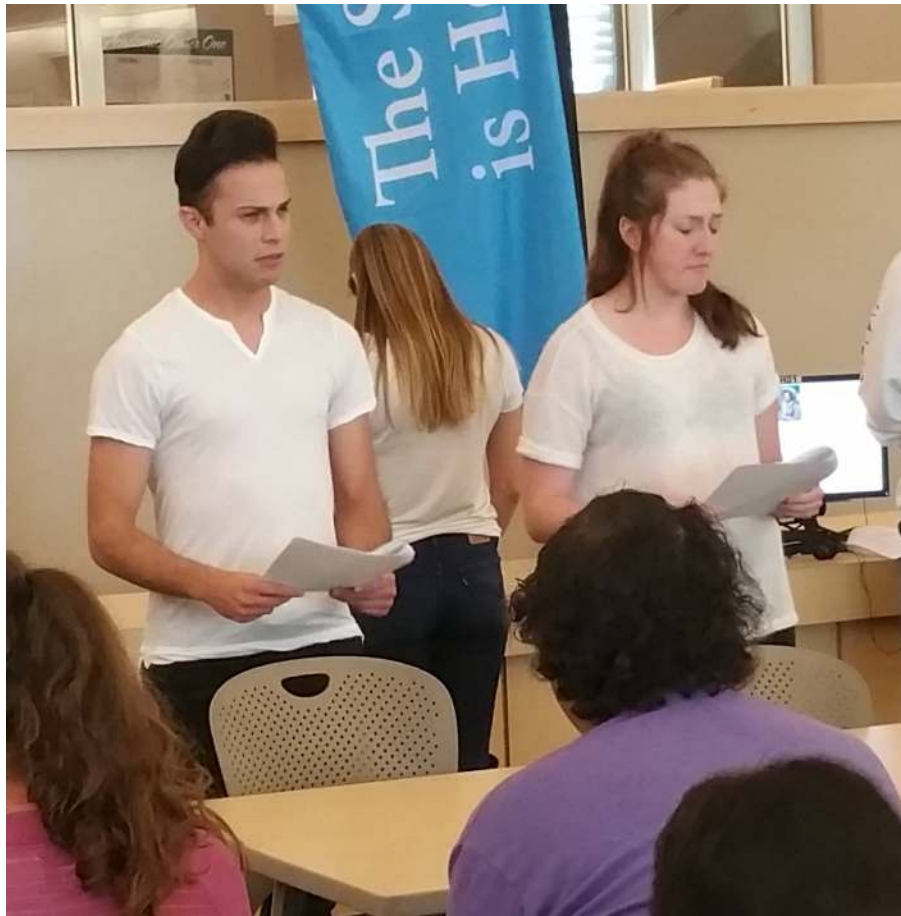
Selecting one longer text for performance and having to “cut it” appropriately for performance can seem daunting enough. If you add *more* pieces of literature to the mix, it can seem overwhelmingly impossible.

Building Dramatic Action

There is no “proper” way to organize or arrange multiple pieces for performance. In fact, you may find it is most effective for your performance purposes to present an introduction, then literature work A, then work B, then work C for the ending. However, this linear progression is not the only method. You may find that a bit more “hopping around” from piece to piece throughout the performance may create a more appealing performance and do more to amplify the communicative message you desire to convey.

You may find you can create a performance program by organizing various segments of each piece into a compiled arrangement. You might, for example, begin with a little of piece A before presenting an introduction. Then, after the intro, perhaps piece B is the next segment before getting into a little of piece A again. Then, you may decide to present a bit of piece C before going back to a different segment of piece A before finally ending on piece D. You may liken this style to a classical music symphony where several different musical segments ebb and flow, appear and reappear, throughout the several-minutes long composition.

When using multiple pieces of literature, try to abandon the idea of telling a story. Instead, focus on the goal of imparting a theme, message, or persuasive thesis to your audience through the interpretation of your chosen literature. However, remember that you still want to create a “build” of sorts with your program and the progression of the literature, regardless of how it is arranged (see Freytag’s elements of dramatic structure in chapter 9). As mentioned previously, you will find it helpful if you know the exact segment with which you want to end the performance. You can find ways to organize the other literature pieces that build to that moment, making your total performance take on qualities like a symphony – ebbs and flows of emotion and ideas, culminating in the final thought/mood on which you choose to end.



Students, Adam Nunez and Storm McNerney, in an emotional performance moment, Clovis Community College, 2016

Example

I put together a Programmed Oral Interpretation (POI, or “mixed genre”) performance for the competitive collegiate forensics circuit in the late 1990’s that honored women serving in wars. I find it helpful to share how I put this program together with my students as they learn to combine and organize multiple pieces for a performance. This is not the only way to create a performance of this type, but you may find the process inspiring as you work with literature you want to place in a program.

In the year I created this performance, I was taking a Vietnam Literature class for my English degree. The professor had us read a book about the experiences of a woman who served as a nurse in the Vietnam War, *Home Before Morning*, by Lynda Van Devanter. As soon as I had read the first page, I knew it would be a great POI for competition. As I read, I bookmarked and sectioned out many different segments and paragraphs that I wanted to include in my performance. Coincidentally, the next book he had us read was a collection of poems written by women who had served in various conflicts, and I found a few that I also considered including in my program. A program honoring women veterans had started to sprout.

At that point, I had about 30 minutes of material that I needed to whittle down to less than 10. I knew that I wanted the Van Devanter piece to be how I started and ended my program. So, I decided one particularly heart wrenching moment would be my ending. It’s a moment where the main character is completely broken because of what she saw in Vietnam. Once I had that decided, I realized I wanted the naivete the character shows in the beginning of the book to be my opening. I was starting to picture a slow deterioration of her character throughout the performance as I moved through various experiences she endured.

Next, I had to decide how and where to include the two poems I had found and which other segments of Van Devanter’s story would make the cut. I decided to take three other moments that highlighted the slow degradation of her hope and courage: her altruistic tendencies as a child, the moment she got off the plane in Vietnam, when she saw soldiers on both sides committing horrific human acts, and a moment when her father is recording a taped message to her chronicling the ridiculous “drama” he’s

experiencing at home in America. I saw the entire performance building up to the most dramatic moment in the book that I had decided would be the program's end.

So, I placed the two poems in places where they matched the emotion Van Devanter had just experienced in the previous segment. After her child memories of playing nurse, I included a somewhat hopeful and sweet poem about a bond a nurse shared with a Vietnamese child she had met while serving (*Vô Ti Truong*, by Lady Borton), highlighting the rare positive experiences one might get from serving others and one's country. The other poem, a sarcastic take on how some American family members felt about their loved ones serving in the war (*Letters From Home*, by Dana Schuster), I placed right after Van Devanter's father's monologue to further amplify the view that so many Americans had no idea what troops and medical staff were dealing with in Vietnam.

Lastly, I wrote my introduction to include the message I wanted to highlight, and I was left to practice and perform.

Over the years, this program has morphed several times. As a performing artist and creator, I find that my work has the most impact when it grows with me. Changes to this performance include things like changing the way I would portray a particular character, rewording my introduction, and even swapping out one of the poems for a dialogue piece as I changed assignment requirements in my classes.

You will find a recording of one of the iterations of this program here: <https://youtu.be/CAQBrrStGpc>.

You can see another example of a performance that uses multiple pieces of arranged literature here: <https://youtu.be/7ejpYmOtaQY>.

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1.10: Group Interpretation and Readers Theatre

Interpretation of literature is not something you can only do solo. There are many forms of group oral interpretation. Group performances can be amazingly creative and, in some ways, more entertaining than a stage play since the performers are freed from the burden of using costumes, set pieces, makeup, and backdrops. Group interpretive performances also often involve more than script literature. Just like solo interpretation, groups can perform essays, poetry, speeches, and more.

Types

There are a few forms of group performance. You may be familiar with one of them if your primary school teacher(s) ever had you perform a poem with others in front of your class or school. Known as choral reading, this type of interpretation emphasizes performers reciting lines together, typically with highly rehearsed and synchronized vocal tone and body language.

This chapter, however, will explore one form of group interpretation in more depth. Readers Theatre is a particular form of group interp where two or more performers emphasize a particular theme or message through the performance of one or more texts. Just like solo interp performance, participants do not use costumes, props, set pieces, lighting, or makeup, so the group must be creative in the way participants use their bodies and voices to communicate things like setting and context (if needed). Like most oral interpretation performances for adult audiences, the emphasis is less on telling a story and more on highlighting a particular communicative message, thesis, or idea. Due to this, performing groups are less bound to typical storytelling parameters like having an exposition, plot, or resolution.

Features

Similar to solo interpretative performances, Readers Theatre performances also typically involve:

- No (or very limited) costumes, props, set pieces, and other typical stage play resources.
- One or more pieces of literature.
- An introduction highlighting the title(s)/author(s) of pieces and performance thesis, message, or significance to the audience.
- Performers holding their scripts and sometimes even using them as props.
- Use of off-stage focal points (except for the introduction).
- Performers portraying more than one persona throughout the program.

Since Readers Theatre involves more than one person, this spawns interesting opportunities for performers to employ creative group performance techniques such as:

- Performing a one-voice piece using multiple voices/participants.
- Performers becoming backgrounds, sound effects, animation, and inanimate objects.
- Performing certain lines in a choral fashion with multiple participants speaking at once.
- Performers playing more than just one persona in a program.
- Some performers creating frozen or slow-moving background tableaux while others perform the words of a piece.
- Creating the visual appearance of a synchronized team.
 - Readers Theatre participants traditionally wear black to remain versatile enough to play multiple personas, but groups will often dress in attire appropriate to the theme of their program.
 - Physical scripts are all identical and performers synchronize page turning during performance.



Figure 1.10.1: Students in a readers theatre performance, dressed similarly and using phones as script, Clovis Community College, 2015

Advantages

The words “group work” often conjure a slew of curse words in people who have had horrible experiences. However, group work offers a host of advantages that can make the final product better than if only one person had worked on the project. With multiple brains thinking, imagining, and pouring energy into a project, amazing ideas spring up. Analyzing a script alone, for example, you may have never thought about performing the main character with an accent or assigning certain participants to pose as trees during a forest scene.

When participants in a group commit to a project, it can result in less pressure and stress about the whole project. More hands on deck can feel like less of a workload on all involved. Additionally, as humans are social creatures, the time participants spend in analysis, rehearsal, and performance together increases the fun factor significantly, particularly when group members are a bit nervous when performing solo. Plus, when people perform with others, there is a certain energy that sizzles among participants and often results in performers “kicking it up a notch” a bit more than they would in performance by themselves.

Challenges and Advice

Group work can, at times, be frustrating. These are busy times, and participants are often balancing jobs, family life, etc. Different personalities with different work habits might sometimes result in conflict. However, if you approach a group project with a positive outlook and begin work early with your group, you will often be more pleased with the final product than you ever would have been if you had worked alone.

Follow this advice during your time working on a group performance project:

- Always stay in touch with your group members as you prepare the performance. No excuses. *Tell* them with your words and *show* them with your behavior that you are in it to win it and that you want to complete your share of the work. If you are not planning to complete the project, be honest and up front so your group can move on without you. You will avoid hard feelings this way if you do it in a timely manner.
- As you begin your work together, if you have truly tried to get in touch with group members and they don't seem ready to begin, you should start working. Find some pieces you might be able to do, come up with a theme, write an introduction. When you do finally get a hold of some members, you can tell them what you have already done and divide up duties on what still needs to happen. Sometimes, members just need to see that a little something has been done to kick start their motivation to begin.
- Listen to one another. Be sure to include brainstorming sessions to generate ideas, allowing all members to voice their thoughts without judgment (refer to chapter 12 for the subject of listening).
- Talk to your instructor/coach if you are having repeated issues with a member. But, this should be done only after all other means of communication with the member have been exhausted.

Group work, as frustrating as it can be, does not go away, ever, even once you begin a career or start a family. However, it can be highly rewarding and productive. You must, however, remain patient, persistent, and sometimes be willing to begin the project if

others are slow in getting started.

Preparation

You should begin your Readers Theatre journey by getting to know your group mates. You will be collaborating with them for a couple of weeks at the very least, and in most cases, even longer. If possible, engage in some creative, team-building exercises with them (hopefully your instructor will guide you through some of these if you are in a course).

Then, your group can begin to look for literature you might want to perform or decide on a theme/message/thesis you may want to impart to your audience. If you have a piece of literature in mind, discuss messages or themes in that literature with your group and what other texts you might add to the program (if needed). The other pieces of literature you might add should have something to add to the theme/message/thesis you see highlighted in that first “base” piece you examined. Or, if you have a theme you want to explore, your group should start brainstorming and finding various literature pieces that would fit well together in your Readers Theatre program.

As you consider adding and arranging the texts into your program, keep variety in mind. Your pieces should all have something a little different to “say” about the message you are sharing with your audience. Consider the advice from the previous chapter on arranging literature for a performance and building dramatic action. Create a “symphony” of mood, emotion, and/or tone with the various pieces in your program.

Even while you are in the collecting, organizing, and sorting process, begin preliminary performance work right away. Read the lines aloud with one another to make some early casting assignments, play with body language and staging, and discuss what might be happening visually in each segment. It is easy for a group to start to feel too comfortable sitting around and chatting about the project and getting up and performing with your peers nearby can be a bit nerve-wracking. Start it early so that you have more time feeling comfortable taking chances with one another and your performance choices.

Rehearsal

Once you’ve organized your literature and perhaps even written your introduction, the physical rehearsal stage can begin. You can make final casting choices, assigning particular lines/paragraphs/words to members. You can also stage the movement in the program, also known as “blocking.” It is in this stage where the creativity of multiple brains can really make a program special. Often, those doing group interpretation for the first time cannot help but feel they require elements such as furniture, costumes, a “backstage” area, etc. because those are the types of performances they are used to seeing. But, they soon realize that those things are not necessary and can actually restrict their creative abilities. In oral interpretation, performers are limited only by their imaginations. Consider some of these Readers Theatre techniques that are often used to take the place of some typical staged play or movie scene elements:

- **Entrances/Exits:** Since there is no backstage area, performers who are not in a segment or who are entering/exiting a scene can simply bow their heads, turn around, move behind other performers, or sit when necessary.
- **Transitions:** In plays or movies, lights dim or there is a change in physical location when moving from one scene to another. So, when transitioning out of one text to another in a Readers Theatre program, performers can turn around, move positions, do slight head bows, etc. The group could even chant a line each time a new piece is about to begin. Be creative and clear in your choices, and audiences will know when you have moved into a new piece of literature or a new scene.
- **Time:** Makeup, lighting, set design, and more can help indicate when time has passed or characters have aged in movies and plays. In interp, group members can move in slow motion, speed up significantly, or even freeze completely to indicate time elements.
- **Haptics and touch:** We are accustomed to seeing actors interacting in natural space in plays or movies, hugging one another, shaking hands, etc. Since interpretation uses off-stage focal points, groups must be creative in how they communicate these sorts of actions in performance. For example, two performers whose characters shake hands must watch one another peripherally and synchronize their hand movement with excellent timing to communicate that mutual gesture.
- **Scenery:** Since interp does not employ backdrops or elaborate furniture pieces as environment cues for the audience, Readers Theatre performers can become these items. Consider, for example, having two performers with raised arms forming an arch around another performer to communicate the balcony scene in *Romeo and Juliet*. Or, perhaps multiple performers can stand behind Santiago and sway to become the ocean as he fishes in his boat in an excerpt from *Old Man and the Sea*.



Figure 1.10.2: Students in a readers theatre performance with their backs turned in transition between pieces, Clovis Community College, 2016

The possibilities are endless. And, what is so freeing about this style of performance is that since groups are not using bulky set pieces and costumes, performers can move quickly in and out of these positions and situations to be ready for the next segment.

For a great example of many of these techniques from this chapter in action, look at this example Readers Theatre: <https://youtu.be/XRApnrzZ9UQ>.

Keys to a Successful Group Performance

The keys with Readers Theatre and group interpretation performance are creativity and flexibility. Think outside of the usual boxes. If you are performing a text that you have once seen as a movie, do not reduce your performance to being a simple imitation of what you have seen. Examine the words as they exist on the page and consider the myriad ways you can present these words to the audience to highlight your chosen message. If something you try with your group does not seem to be working, be flexible enough to adjust. Work as a team and enjoy the final product when you perform it together for your audience.



Figure 1.10.3: Student, Jacob Moon, initiating his group's performance, Clovis Community College, 2015

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1.11: Composing Introductions and Transitions

While most of the time in an oral interpretation performance is spent presenting literature, there are a few moments within the performance where the audience members should see you, the performer, guiding their focus toward the significance of your chosen piece(s) and the purpose of your performance.

These performer-authored moments are considered separate from the literature. The performer usually indicates this separation by making sure the literature script(s) is closed and presenting these moments in a memorized fashion or from a separate note card or paper, with direct eye contact toward the audience. These moments are typically written in a straightforward style in the performer's own voice, and they should sound conversational and be personable in delivery style, much like the performer might naturally sound while delivering a casual speech.

These moments typically take the form of introductions and transitions.

Introductions

One specific characteristic of oral interpretation is the often-present introduction. This is a brief paragraph written by the performer that is placed toward the beginning of a performance. Its purpose is to impart relevance, connecting the literature and the performance to the audience. Essentially, it tells the audience why the literature and the performance are important and what lesson the audience can learn or theme they can celebrate because of it.

Elements of an Introduction

An oral interp intro generally contains the following elements:

- Attention getter. Also known as a “hook,” this is the very first part of your introduction. It is the first time we are seeing and hearing you when you begin your performance, so it should be something that makes us want to continue to listen. When you deliver this moment, you should exude confidence. There are several techniques you can use as an attention getter:
 - Teaser – This is a short segment of the literature that is being performed.
 - Question – Get your audience thinking about your performance by asking them something. You can either solicit responses or let it be rhetorical.
 - Quote – Similar to the way you might use a famous quote in a speech, you can begin your performance in a similar fashion. Use a quote that relates to the message you have chosen to highlight in your literature.
 - Joke – Using humor is an effective attention getter, assuming it is connected to the performance theme somehow.
 - Startling research/fact/statistic – Citing your source immediately afterward, you can begin your performance with a relevant piece of information that reveals insight about your literature or your message.
 - More! – There are many other sorts of attention getters, from dancing to singing to sign language to foreign language... basically, anything other than, “Hi, my name is _____, and I’m doing (title and author) for you today” can work.
- Title and author. You should clearly state these for each piece of literature that appears in your performance. If an author is unknown, you should say so. If you are using work from a movie or television show, the screenwriter(s) is considered the author. You don’t need to cite illustrators as the words are what you are sharing, not the pictures. You should also be sure to state all authors if there are multiple ones for any particular work.
- Message/moral/relation statement. This is a sentence that tells the audience why they should pay attention for the next several minutes. The statement should include the word “you,” “we,” or “us,” and it should explain the message/theme/moral/lesson of the literature that you discovered through your analysis of the work.
- Personal connection statement. This sentence gives the performance a personal quality and explains to the audience why this particular literature or message/theme is important to you. This statement should include the words “I” or “me.”
- Background information or context (optional). If your literature is a cutting of a larger work or if it is so heavy in rhetorical context that the audience must understand a bit more in order to grasp the meaning of the work you wish to convey, you can provide some brief information to get an audience up to speed. For example, if you are doing chapter 11 of a novel, you may need to explain what has happened in the previous ten chapters or give us background on the main character before beginning your selection.

The order of these elements, except for the attention getter, does not matter. You may even find that you can use the personal connection or relation statement as the attention getter.

Considerations for Writing/Delivering the Introduction

Once you have a rough idea of what you'd like to say in your introduction, you may want to keep the following in mind as you polish it and begin to practice delivering it.

- Ensure that your theme/message/thesis is something relatively universal. It should be something to which many people can relate. This means you should do a good amount of audience analysis before finalizing this theme for your performance. Consider your audience members' cultures, ages, gender affiliations, socioeconomic statuses, political affiliations, interests, etc.
- Avoid detail about the plot of your piece. Let that develop as you perform. If you must go into plot in your intro, limit it to only one sentence. We want to see societal relevance and a connection to ourselves.
- Be you in the introduction, not a character. The intro should sound more neutral and natural compared to the piece itself. Most of the emotion and feeling in your performance should be demonstrated through the literature, not the intro.
- Remember to either memorize your introduction or use a notecard or paper that is separate from your literature script.
- Aim to limit your introduction to no more than 10% or less of the time of your entire performance.

Sample Introductions

To help in your own composition of a performance introduction, here are some samples. You will see that each intro element has been labeled in brackets to help you identify them more easily (you would not say these words in the actual performance).

Sample Intro for a Single-Piece Performance

[attention getter] "What defines responsibility when it comes to a divorce? [theme/message/relation] Is it better to stay together for the sake of the kids, or is it better to break the ties and get on with our lives? As future parents, this is a decision we may all have to eventually face, whether we want to or not. [personal connection] My parents finally divorced when I was 12 after a decade of misery together, and I'm still not certain what I feel is the best choice. [background info] In this piece, Joanie Marcus is faced with this decision when her chronically irresponsible husband comes back to her claiming that he has changed. [title and author] Little Footsteps, by Ted Tally.

Sample Intro for a Multiple-Piece Performance

[attention getter] An estimated 15,000 women served in the Vietnam War: nurses, staffers, volunteers. In all of our wars, women have been killed, maimed, disabled, and most of all psychologically injured. [theme/message/relation] But, they are the forgotten veterans, and it is our duty to remember them. [personal connection] I became attached to this cause after taking a college course in Vietnam-themed literature and felt pulled to create this program in tribute to these wonderful women. The Women Wounded: a program including Home Before Morning, prose by Lynda VanDervanter, "Vo Thi Troung," poetry by Lady Borton, and "Letter from Home," poetry by Dana Schuster [titles and authors]. Here, women's voices are heard as they cry for recognition.

Transitions

Particularly when arranging multiple pieces of literature for performance, a beginning performer may not know how to transition from one piece to another. You may feel a need to include mini-intro-style "bridges" between the pieces to help your audience members refocus or to shift their attention more directly to a new thought or idea. In these moments, you can close your literature

script and speak directly to the audience, using your own words in a natural, conversational style (similar to the vibe of an introduction) to tell the audience directly what you feel is necessary to understand the movement from one piece to the next.

While this may seem as though it should be the default method when a performer is using multiple pieces to minimize audience confusion as to which piece is which, these transitions are not always necessary, and can sometimes break the momentum of the “symphony” of build and emotion that you’ve created with your arrangement of the works. Instead of direct, separate-from-the-literature transitions, you can simply use a page turn and a change in body language and/or voice to indicate a shift in literature, mood, or thought.

However, there are times where you might feel like the message of a piece is best conveyed if you do provide transitions throughout the performance. If so, it is best when these transitions are brief. They should make a quick reference to the literature or segment that was just heard before moving on to the next.

For example, let’s say you are doing a multiple-piece interpretation program with a theme of “the hidden dangers of fairy tales.” If you just finished the last moments of *Cinderella* and are transitioning into *Beauty and the Beast*, you would close your script and address the audience directly either through memorization of the following or using a separate note card/paper to assist you:

“So, Cinderella’s story could potentially teach children that a woman’s life will only be satisfying if she finds a rich man to marry. This is not the only dangerous message these tales can send to children. As we see in Beauty and the Beast, the message sent about appropriate relationships could be even more sinister.”

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1.12: Listening To and Evaluating Oral Interpretation Performance

To become good at anything, we must not only *do*. We must also *observe*.

In this course, you will benefit just as much from watching your peers and other performers do interp as you will from doing it yourself. By examining and evaluating other interpretation presentations, considering the performers' choices of literature and arrangements/organization, introductions, confidence levels, vocal characteristics, body language, and characterizations, you can learn a great deal about what sorts of choices work in interp. From there, you can make decisions to improve your future performances.

But, to better evaluate oral interpretation performances, you must first focus on listening skills.

The Importance of Listening

Understanding how listening works provides the foundation we need to explore why we listen, including various types and styles of listening. In general, listening helps us achieve important communication goals. Listening is also important in academic, professional, and personal contexts.

In terms of academics, poor listening skills have been shown to contribute significantly to failure in a person's first year of college (Zabava & Wolvin, 1993). In general, students with high scores for listening ability have greater academic achievement. Potential employers openly value listening skills, with this trait consistently ranking in the top ten in national surveys (National Association of Colleges and Employers, 2010).

Poor listening skills, lack of conciseness, and inability to give constructive feedback have been identified as potential communication challenges in professional contexts. Even though listening education is lacking in our society, research has shown that introductory communication courses provide important skills necessary for functioning in entry-level jobs, including listening, writing, motivating/persuading, interpersonal skills, informational interviewing, and small-group problem solving (DiSalvo, 1980). So, while this chapter may be focused primarily on how you can listen better to evaluate your peers' performances, the constructive feedback skills you will learn will pay off down the road, even if you never watch another performance.

The following list reviews some of the main functions of listening that are relevant in multiple contexts (Hargie, 2011):

- to focus on messages sent by other people or noises coming from our surroundings
- to better our understanding of another person's communication
- to critically evaluate other people's messages
- to monitor nonverbal signals
- to indicate that we are interested or paying attention
- to empathize with others and show we care for them (relational maintenance), and
- to engage in negotiation, dialogue, or other exchanges that result in shared understanding of or agreement on an issue.

At some point in the semester, you will use each one of these listening functions as you work with and evaluate your peers in class.

Listening Types

Listening serves many purposes, and different situations require different types of listening. The type of listening we engage in affects our communication and how others respond to us. In this course, as we listen to our peers perform, we may need to employ a few different types of listening to provide good feedback.

The main types of listening that may apply in this course are discriminative, informational, critical, and empathetic (Watson, Barker, & Weaver III, 1995).

Discriminative Listening

Discriminative listening is a focused and usually instrumental type of listening that is primarily physiological and occurs mostly at the receiving stage of the listening process. Here we engage in listening to scan and monitor our surroundings to isolate particular auditory or visual stimuli. In the absence of a hearing impairment, we have an innate and physiological ability to engage in discriminative listening. Although this is the most basic form of listening, it provides the foundation on which more intentional listening skills are built. This type of listening can be refined and honed. Think of how musicians, singers, and mechanics exercise

specialized discriminative listening to isolate specific aural stimuli and how actors, detectives, and sculptors discriminate visual cues that allow them to analyze, make meaning from, or recreate nuanced behavior (Wolvin & Coakley, 1993).

We must begin with discriminative listening when we settle in to watch, listen to, and evaluate an oral interpretation performance, clearing our minds and bodies from all distractions, to give the performer our full and undivided attention. We can accomplish this by silencing our phones, avoiding other tasks, directing our eyes, ears, and heart toward the performer, and losing ourselves for a time in the world they have created for us.

Informational Listening

Informational listening entails listening with the goal of comprehending and retaining information. This type of listening is not evaluative and is common in teaching and learning contexts ranging from a student listening to a teacher to an out-of-towner listening to directions to the nearest gas station. We also use informational listening when we listen to news reports, voice mail, and briefings at work.

Since retention and recall are important components of informational listening, good concentration and memory skills are key. These also happen to be skills that many college students struggle with, at least in the first years of college, but will be expected to have mastered once they get into professional contexts. In many professional contexts, informational listening is important, especially when receiving instructions. Truthfully, you will be expected to process verbal instructions more frequently in your profession than you here in college. Most college professors provide detailed instructions and handouts with assignments so you can review them as needed, but many supervisors and managers will expect you to take the initiative to remember or record vital information. Additionally, many bosses are not as open to questions or requests to repeat themselves as professors are.

When you watch a performance for evaluative purposes either in the classroom, online, or in professional or live setting, you will likely receive a set of instructions on what and how to accomplish this task. You will use informational listening at this time to understand the requirements.

You will also engage in a bit of informational listening while you watch certain performances. Even though you will be often watching your peers for evaluative purposes, you will undoubtedly learn a few new things along the way. You will come away from some performances with a new perspective on an old cliché or an appreciation for a culture of which you were previously unaware. You will probably also be banking some ideas for your future performances based on what you see your peers doing with their own.

Critical Listening

Critical listening entails listening with the goal of analyzing or evaluating a message based on information presented verbally and information that can be inferred from context. A critical listener evaluates a message and accepts it, rejects it, or decides to withhold judgment and seek more information. You can see judges employ critical listening, with varying degrees of competence, on talent competition shows like *RuPaul's Drag Race*, *America's Got Talent*, and *The Voice*. While the exchanges between judge and contestant on these shows is expected to be subjective and critical, critical listening is also important when listening to speakers that have stated or implied objectivity, such as parents, teachers, political leaders, doctors, and religious leaders.

Critical-listening skills are useful when listening to and evaluating performances in this class. This is often scary for beginning performers who feel they are too inexperienced to offer any kind of valuable feedback. However, as an experienced audience member, you have more of an eye/ear for good performance than you think, and if paired with a kind, helpful, and constructive approach, your feedback will not only be valuable to your peers, but welcome.

Empathetic Listening

When we listen to empathize with others, our messages will likely be supportive and open, which will then lead the other person to feel “heard” and supported and hopefully view the interaction positively (Bodie & Villaume, 2003).

Empathetic listening is the most challenging form of listening and occurs when we try to understand or experience what a speaker is thinking or feeling. Because of our own centrality in our perceptual world, empathetic listening can be difficult. It's often much easier for us to tell our own story or to give advice than it is to really listen to and empathize with someone else.

When you listen to others' interpretation performances, listening empathetically can help us expand our self and social awareness by learning from other people's experiences and by helping us take on different perspectives. Additionally, since performers are

free to choose their own literature and highlight the messages from it that they feel are important, oral interp performances can often be very personal. So, it is important that while you listen critically in order to provide helpful feedback to your peers to improve their future performances, you must also listen with empathy in order to get a sense of their motives for creating the performance in the first place. This perspective approach will help you construct your feedback in an even more helpful manner.

Making use of all types of listening styles in this course will not only help you become a better oral interpretation performer, but quite certainly also a better listener in general.

Attributions

Evaluation Categories for Oral Interpretation

You can help your peers and learn to improve your own performances by evaluating performances in several categories, all of which have been explored in this text, and many (if not all) upon which your instructor will likely score your performances. Using an empathetic yet critical ear and eye, you can give positive and constructive feedback on:

- Introductions – Are all required elements mentioned? Does it set the appropriate tone for the rest of the performance? Is it conversational and natural and written by the performer?
- Literature – Does it meet the touchstones of literary merit appropriate for performance? Is the cutting of the literature, if present, effective?
- Transitions – If present, are they necessary and effective? If not present, are they needed?
- Familiarity – Does the performer look up from the literature while performing it a majority of the time?
- Focal points – Does the performer seem to understand to whom each character in his/her program is speaking? Do they provide effective and appropriate focal points to help the audience see this conversation?
- Voice – Does the performer make effective use of vocal variation to establish emotion, feeling, and characterization?
- Body language - Does the performer make effective use of various body language techniques to establish emotion, feeling, and characterization?
- Time – Does the entire performance fall within the expected time range?

This is not an exhaustive list. You may think of other important considerations upon which you may want to comment as you watch any performance.

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1.13: Conclusion

So, you've concluded this class in Oral Interpretation of Literature. Now what? Broadway? Community theatre? Slam poetry readings? Open mic nights? Perhaps!

Or, perhaps not.

Perhaps you will use the skills from this class in subtler and more frequent ways. As discussed in chapter 1, think of the various ways that you "perform" every day. Consider how much more effective the communication of any verbal message can be with expressive nonverbal accompaniment. In your personal life and career, you will be asked to perform multiple times in the theatre of life. As you shift in and out of various roles (from student to manager to significant other to caregiver and more), you must be flexible and real in your portrayal of them. Almost everything we do requires some level of performance, from managing interpersonal relationships to building a career.

Perhaps you will also use your skills to look at art in new ways. Song lyrics might take on new meaning, you may see deeper significance in movies or plays. As you move through stages of life, you will use your analysis skills to examine art you thought you understood and discover new themes based on your values, beliefs, and experiences that have changed you over time.

Or, perhaps the most tangible way you will use these skills will be as you read a story to an important child in your life. She will look at you, wide-eyed and ready to listen, as she hands you her favorite book. You will regale her with different character voices, expressive faces, and ability to chat with her afterwards about what the book meant to her. And maybe, just maybe, you will create your own little oral interpretation performer.



Figure 1.13.1: Student, Ala'a Jibril, reading to children, Clovis Community College, 2016

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